GERMANPEDIA
PRESENTS

GERMAN HEALTHCARE



A PRACTICAL GUIDE TO GERMAN HEALTHCARE FOR INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS

Guide on German Healthcare for International Students

Copyright © 2024 GermanPedia

All rights reserved. No part of this publication may be reproduced, stored in, or introduced into a retrieval system or transmitted in any form or by any means (electronic, mechanical, photocopying, recording, or otherwise) without the prior written permission of the publisher.

Cover art © GermanPedia

This book is not intended to provide personalized, legal, financial, or any kind of advice. The Authors specifically disclaim any liability, loss, or risk that is incurred as a consequence, directly or indirectly, of the use and application of any contents of this work.

GermanPedia and the Authors refer to helpful services and do not provide a complete market overview. The information provided in this book is based on our own experience and in-depth research. We are not certified brokers or consultants.

GermanPedia
Neibergalstr. 20
12557 Berlin, Germany
www.germanpedia.com

Guide on German Healthcare for International Students

Overview **7**
German health system 8
Historical Context 8
Types of health insurance in Germany 9
How can you get German Health Insurance? 12
Healthcare cost **14**
Health insurance premium 15
Out-of-pocket costs in public health insurance 18
Out-of-pocket-costs in private health insurance 26
Healthcare coverage **27**
Overview 28
What is not covered by health insurance in Germany? 30
Difference between public and private health insurance **32**
Overview 33
Private health insurance pros and cons 36
Public health insurance pros and cons 38
How do you access healthcare in Germany? **39**
How do you find a doctor in Germany? 40
How do you pay for the medical services in Germany? 40
How do you access health services in Germany? 41
Navigating the German healthcare system as an expat 43
Sick leave **45**
Who is entitled to sick pay? 46
Who doesn't get sick pay? 47
When do you get sick pay? 47
What should you consider when getting sick notice from the doctor? 48
What do you have to do to get sick pay? 49
How much is sick pay in Germany? 51
How long is the paid sick leave period? 52
Is sick pay tax-free? 53
Resolving trouble with your health insurance company? 54

What happens after paid sick leave ends? 59
Child sickness benefits 61
Legal basis of child sickness benefits 62
Who can claim child sickness benefits? 62
Requirements you must fulfill to receive child sick pay 63
How do you apply for child sickness benefits? 64
How many days of child sickness benefits can you receive? 65
How much is the child sick pay? 67
Do you have to declare child sick pay in the income tax returns? 67
Family health insurance 69
What are the requirements for free family insurance? 70
Who can be insured under family health insurance for free in Germany? 71
How do you apply for free family health insurance? 72
What are the income limits to get free family health insurance in Germany? 72
What do the insurer consider as income for family insurance? 73
What to do if your income exceeds the income limit later? 74
When can you not insure your children for free in family insurance? 74
What happens when family insurance ends? 75
Best public health insurance companies 76
How did we find the best public health insurance provider in Germany? 77
Comparison of public health insurance services 78
Are there significant differences in public health insurance companies in Germany? 80
Cheapest public health insurance companies in Germany 81
Why are some public health insurance providers more expensive than others? 81
How do you switch public health insurance in Germany? 83
What should you keep in mind when changing public health insurance companies? 84
What is the special right to terminate your public health insurance? 85
Best private health insurance companies 86
Things you should know about the ratings 87
Best private health insurance in Germany (Summary) 87
Best private health insurance plans per Handelsblatt 2023 89
Best private health insurance plans per Focus Money 2023 91
Best private health insurance plans per Morgen & Morgen 2024 92
Best private health insurance companies per Map-Report 2023 94
Best private health insurance companies per IVFP 2023 95
Best private health insurance companies per DFSI 2023 97

Future outlook..... 100
Break up of private health insurance premium..... 101
How do private health insurers calculate the monthly premium?..... 102
Difference between public and private health insurance premium calculations.....103
How much did the private health insurance premium rise in the past?.....106
Why do private health insurance costs rise abruptly in Germany?..... 109
Reasons for the increase in private health insurance costs in Germany.....110
Is private health insurance unaffordable in old age?.....111
How much do you pay for private health insurance before and after retirement?..... 112
Does private health insurance get more expensive than public over time?..... 115
How can private health insurance offer better services at a lower cost than public health insurance?..... 119
Future outlook of health insurance costs in Germany..... 119
Resources.....123
Useful links..... 124
Other books..... 124
Disclaimer..... 124
Version History..... 125

Overview

German health system

The German healthcare system is based on solidarity. Everyone gets the same health services regardless of their contributions and health risks.

Germany has two types of health insurance.

- Public health insurance (Gesetzliche Krankenversicherung (GKV))
- Private health insurance (Privat Krankenversicherung (PKV))

Both employers and employees contribute to the health insurance system, along with government subsidies. 89% of Germany's population is insured with public health insurance, and the rest is insured with private insurance.

The German healthcare system provides comprehensive coverage, including

- doctor visits,
- hospital stays,
- preventive care, and
- medications.

Usually, you don't pay anything or very little to access healthcare in Germany.

Historical Context

The German health system is more than 140 years old. German Chancellor Otto von Bismarck laid its foundation in 1883, and the system still reflects Bismarck's original principles.

- Mandatory insurance for every resident
- Shared financing between employers and employees

- Accessible care for all residents

Types of health insurance in Germany

The following types of health insurance are available in Germany

- Public health insurance
- Private health insurance
- Expats health insurance
- Travel health insurance

Expats and travel health insurance are for temporary stays only. If you plan on staying longer than five years in Germany, you must choose between private and public health insurance.

Private and public health insurance overview

Public health insurance	Private health insurance
Definition	
Default health insurance for German residents. The federal government of Germany regulates it.	A voluntary health insurance option. Private insurance companies offer this.
Eligibility and requirements	
Employees: Mandatory if earn below the income threshold (69,300€ gross annually as of 2024). Voluntarily insure themselves if they earn above the income threshold. **Self-employed, freelancers, and doctors:** Voluntarily insure themselves irrespective of income. **Students**: You get public insurance by default if you are under 30 before starting	**Employees**: You must earn above the income threshold (69,300€ gross per annum as of 2024) **Self-employed, freelancers, and doctors:** Voluntarily insure themselves irrespective of income. **Students**: Voluntarily insure themselves. Non-EU students above 30 can only get private insurance.

your studies. However, you can change to private within the first three months of your course start. **Artists:** You must insure yourself with "Artists' Social Insurance Fund (Künstlersozialkasse (KSK))	**NOTE**: Private health insurance can reject your application if you have existing medical conditions.
Costs and contributions	
Contributions are a percentage of your gross monthly income, between 19.9% and 20.3%. As of 2024, the maximum gross monthly salary considered to calculate the premium is 5175€. **Employee**: The premium is split equally between the employee and employer. **Self-employed:** You pay the whole premium yourself. **Student**: Get a special student tariff. It costs between 114€ and 130€ depending on the insurer. **Non-working spouse and children:** You can insure your non-working spouse and children for free in your family health insurance. **Unemployed**: If you earn less than 1178.3 € gross per month and aren't insured for free in family insurance, you pay a minimum premium of around 192.07 € per month (as of 2024). Retired or pensioners: You pay a subsidized health insurance premium. However, you must be insured with statutory insurance for at least 90 percent of the time in the second half of your working life.	Premiums depend on your age, health, and chosen coverage. For a healthy 35-year-old, it costs around 650€. **Employee**: The premium is split equally between the employee and employer. However, employer pays at most what they may have paid if you were insured with public insurance. **Self-employed, unemployed, doctors:** You pay the whole premium yourself. **Student**: No special student tariff. **Non-working spouse and children:** You must get a separate policy for your non-working spouse and children. Child: 90 € to 120 € per month **Retired or pensioners:** Your pension insurance pays a subsidy, and you cover the rest. The retirement provision you saved over time is also used to reduce the premium.

Coverage and benefits	
You get a health insurance card. You show the card and can avail yourself of health services without paying a cent. Coverage includes doctor visits, hospital care, prescriptions, and preventive care.	Coverage depends on the plan you choose. You can tailor the coverage based on your needs. In addition to public insurance coverage, you can access private hospital rooms, shorter waiting times, the latest medical treatments, etc.

Travel and expat health insurance

Travel health insurance	Expats health insurance
Definition	
Travel health insurance covers your medically necessary treatment costs in Germany and other Schengen countries during your visit. It is also known as incoming health insurance (Incoming Versicherung).	Expat health insurance is similar to travel health insurance. However, it is available for stays up to five years in Germany.
Who is it for?	
It's for tourists visiting Germany.	It's for students, visa seekers, post-doctorates, and interns. Freelancers not eligible for private or public insurance can also get it.
NOTE: You must get private or public health insurance if you work full-time in Germany.	
Coverage	
• Covers the cost of treatments for non-pre-existing diseases • Accidents and emergencies • Repatriation costs: Travel costs to return to your home country for treatment. • Coverage in Germany and the EU.	
What is not covered?	
• Pre-existing diseases	

• Routine checkups • Vaccinations • Mental health services, such as psychotherapy, psychiatry, etc.
Duration
Up to five years

> **NOTE:** If you are planning to stay in Germany, you should get either public or private health insurance. Travel and expat health insurance do not offer comprehensive coverage and are for short/temporary stays only.

How can you get German Health Insurance?

First, you must determine which health insurance, private or public, best suits your needs. You can use our "Health Insurance Finder" tool to do this.

Statutory health insurance

There are 96 public health insurance companies in Germany. Some of the big names are TK, AOK, Barmer, and HKK. We found TK, the best public health insurer for expats in Germany.

TK (Techniker Krankenkasse) is the biggest health insurance provider based on the number of insured members. It's also expat-friendly and offers a website, mobile app, and customer service in English.

You can register with TK online by using our online registration service.

Private health insurance

Privat health insurance is a complicated product. Thus, we recommend getting it through an insurance broker. Brokers are experts who suggest which policy is best for your needs.

Insurance brokers offer their services for free. The insurance company pays them upon successful contract completion. So, you must contact a broker who you can trust.

You can book an appointment with the insurance broker we recommend here. They have worked in the health insurance domain for over a decade and specialize in helping expats.

> **NOTE**: Insurance brokers are liable for their advice. So, if you bear any damage due to their wrong advice, the broker is liable to pay the damages.

We have created a **checklist** that you can use during your call with the broker. Ensure that the policy your broker recommends covers the points mentioned in the checklist. You can download the checklist for free here.

Expat health insurance

We found the expat health insurance from Feather* and Dr-Walter* among the best. They are not insurance agents and brokers respectively and offer English customer support.

Healthcare cost

Healthcare costs in Germany can be divided into three parts

- Health insurance premium (mandatory)
- Supplementary insurance (optional)
- Out-of-pocket costs (dental costs, medications, etc.)

Health insurance premium

The biggest expense for healthcare in Germany is the insurance premium. Public and private systems calculate the premium differently.

Public health insurance cost

The cost of public health insurance depends on your gross monthly salary. The higher the salary, the more you pay. However, the maximum gross monthly salary considered for calculating the premium is 5175€ as of 2024. Similarly, the minimum gross monthly salary considered for calculating the premium is 1178.3 € as of 2024.

Public health insurance premium calculation varies slightly based on your profession.

Employed/Self-Emplyoed

The public insurance premium is made up of the following parts.

- **General contribution:** 14.6%
- **Additional contribution:** 1.7% (average as of 2024 - health insurers decide its value)
- **Long term care insurance contribution:** 4% (no kids), 3.4% (1 child), 3.15% (2 children), 2.4% (5 children)
- **Total**: 20.3% (no children), 19.7% (1 child)
- For employees, employers contribute half of the premium.

Public health insurance premium = 20.3% or 19.7% of your gross monthly salary

Here is how much you'll pay in public health insurance if you earn 5,175€ or more.

Maximum income considered for calculating premium	5175 € (as of 2024)	
	Percentage of your gross salary	**Monthly premium**
General contribution	14.6%	756.45 € (14.6% of 5175)
Additional contribution (Zusatzbeitrag)	1.7% (average)	88 €
Long-term nursing care	3.4% (with 1 child) 4% (no children)	176 € (with 1 child) 207 € (no children)
Total monthly contribution	19.7% (with 1 child) 20.3% (without children)	1020.45 € (with 1 child) 1051.45 € (without children)

Student

Student health insurance premium depends on your age and number of children. You are eligible for student health insurance if you are under 30. Students who are 30 or above no longer get discounted student health insurance.

The public insurance premium is made up of the following parts.

- **General contribution:** 10.22%
- **Additional contribution:** 1.7% (average as of 2024 - health insurers decide its value)
- **Long term care insurance contribution:** 4% (no kids), 3.4% (1 child), 3.15% (2 children), 2.4% (5 children)

- **Total:** 15.92% (no children)
- The income considered to calculate the premium is 812€ (until 30 Sept. 2024) and 855€ (from 1 Oct. 2024).
- You pay the entire premium.

	Percentage of student rate	**Monthly premium (until 30.09.2024)**	**Monthly premium (from 01.10.2024)**
BAföG rate for students (This is the rate used to calculate student health insurance premiums)		812 €	855 €
General contribution	10.22%	82.99 €	87.38 €
Additional contribution (Zusatzbeitrag)	1.7% (average)	13.8 €	14.53 €
Long-term nursing care	3.4% (with 1 child) 4% (no children)	27.61 € (with children) 32.48 € (no children)	29.07 € (with children) 34.2 € (no children)
Total monthly contribution	15.32% (with 1 child) 15.92% (without children)	124.4 € (with children) 129.27 € (without children)	130.98 € (with children) 136.11 € (without children)

Family

You can insure your non-working spouse and children for free with public health insurance.

More on it later in this book.

Private health insurance cost

Private health insurance premiums don't depend on your income. The insurance cost is based on the following factors.

- **Age**: The older you are when you take the insurance, the more expensive it is.
- **Health**: Private health insurance providers do a complete health check before accepting a new customer. The premium for private health insurance is lower for healthy individuals. A private insurer adds a risk surcharge to your insurance premium if you have an existing disease.
- **Services**: You can select which services you want in your health insurance. The better the services you opt for, the more expensive the private insurance will be.

We made the following assumptions to find the cost of private health insurance plans in Germany.

- You have no prior health problems
- Maximum deductible to 500 € per annum.
- Shared room or 2-bed room in the hospital.

The private health insurance costs for a young individual or **student is around 160 € per month.**

Out-of-pocket costs in public health insurance

You usually pay nothing to access healthcare in Germany. However, you pay a small amount for certain services, such as hospital stays, medical aids, and medications. This is called co-payment.

How much is the co-payment in statutory health insurance?

Despite having the same active ingredient, medications' prices are often very different. This is why public health insurance companies have set the maximum amount they will pay for a group of comparable medications.

Suppose the medication your doctor prescribed is more expensive than the maximum amount set by the insurer. In this case, you must pay the difference plus a co-payment.

The co-payment amount depends on the medical service. The table below summarizes the medical services and co-payments publicly insured individuals must pay.

Area	Co-payment / Additional payment	Exceptions
Medicines and dressings	For prescribed medicines, you pay 10% of the price, but at least 5€ and a maximum of 10€ per pack. However, you never pay more than the actual cost of the drug.	**Example**: - The medicine costs 7€. You pay a co-payment of 5€. - The medicine costs 75€. You pay a co-payment of 7.5€. - The medicine costs 120€. You pay a co-payment of 10€. **NOTE:** Medicines to “improve the quality of life,” such as Viagra or medication to help you quit smoking, are not covered. It doesn't matter if you have a doctor's prescription.

	Non-prescription and over-the-counter medicines are not covered by public health insurance.	The health insurer makes an exception in the following scenarios and covers the medication costs. - Children up to the age of 12. - Adolescents with developmental disorders up to the age of 18. - Insured persons aged 12 and over for the treatment of serious illnesses. However, the medicines should be part of the standard therapy for serious illnesses.
Travel costs	**Inpatient treatments, rescue trips to the hospital, and ambulance transport:** 10% of the cost per trip, at least 5€ and a maximum of 10€ per trip. You don't pay more than the actual trip cost.	The same copayment amount must also be paid for children.
	Outpatient treatments: Health insurance doesn't cover the travel costs for outpatient treatments.	**Exception**: - The costs for medically necessary trips for outpatient treatment, such as dialysis and chemotherapy, are covered. - Disabled people can also claim the travel costs even if they don't have a disability card.
Home Nursing	10% of the costs for a maximum of 28 days, plus an additional 10€ per prescription.	After 28 days, you don't pay the co-payment; the health insurer covers 100% of the costs.
Household help	10% of the daily costs, at least 5€, and a maximum of 10€ for each day the assistance was used. You don't pay more than the actual costs per day.	

Remedies (e.g. physiotherapy, occupational therapy, voice-speech, podiatry, etc.)	10% of the cost of the product plus 10€ per prescription	**Example**: Your doctor prescribed you four physiotherapy sessions in a prescription. You pay 10€ for the prescription and 10% of the cost of each physiotherapy session.
Medical aids (Hearing aids, walking aids, prostheses, incontinence pads)	10% of the costs, but at least 5€ and a maximum of 10€ per aid. You don't pay more than the actual costs.	**Exception** for consumables, such as feeding tubes or diapers for incontinence: you pay a co-payment of 10% per pack, but a maximum of 10€ per month.
Outpatient intensive care	Copayment depends on where the outpatient care is done.	e.g. in full-time care facilities, you pay 10€ per day e.g. in your home, you pay 10% of the costs plus 10€ per prescription You pay for a maximum of 28 days per calendar year.
Hospital treatment	10€ per calendar day for a maximum of 28 days per year.	
Medical rehabilitation (outpatient and inpatient)	10€ per calendar day	
Follow-up rehabilitation after hospital stay	10€ per calendar day	You pay a co-payment for a maximum of 28 days per calendar year, taking into account the co-payment for hospital treatment
Sociotherapy	10% of the daily costs, at least 5€, and a maximum of 10€ per treatment day. You don't pay more than the cost of the therapy.	

Dentures	Health insurance companies pay fixed subsidies for dental treatment. The fixed subsidy increases if you keep the bonus booklet for five or ten years. The same applies to children.	
Artificial insemination	You pay a co-payment of 50%	

When can you be exempt from the co-payment?

You are exempt from co-payment once you reach the individual burden limit (Section 62 SGB V).

- The individual burden limit is 2% of your annual gross family income.
- The burden limit is 1% of gross family income for chronically ill people.

Once your total co-payment exceeds the individual burden limit, you stop paying the co-payment. There are three ways to stop paying co-payment.

- Once you reach the limit, apply for a co-payment exemption letter from your health insurer. You must provide the receipts as proof. If the insurer approves your application, you'll recieve a co-payment exemption letter. You can show this letter when accessing medical services and don't have to pay a co-payment in that calendar year.
- You can calculate the individual burden limit at the start of the year. Pay the whole co-payment in one go to your health insurer and get the exemption letter. This way, you don't have to save the invoices.

- Collect the receipts throughout the year. Check if you surpass the individual burden limit. If yes, submit the receipts to the public health insurer for reimbursement at the end of the year. The insurer will reimburse the amount that exceeds the limit.

NOTE: You can submit the co-payment application retroactively for up to four years.

How do you calculate the individual burden limit?

- The individual burden limit is 2% of your annual gross family income.
- The individual burden limit is 1% of gross family income for chronically ill people.

How is family income calculated?

The sum of the gross income of all the family members who live in the same household is considered for calculating the burden limit. This means

- Your income,
- Your spouse's or registered partner's income
- Income of your underage children
- Income of children over 18 and covered by family insurance

Here are some scenarios where the income of your children or partner is not considered when calculating individual burden limits.

- If the children have their own health insurance while studying or in training, their income is not considered. It doesn't matter whether they live with you in the same household.
- If you are unmarried, your partner's income is not considered. It doesn't matter whether you and your partner live in the same household.

What counts as income?

Public health insurance companies consider all types of earnings when calculating the co-payment limit. Here are some of the incomes that insurers consider.

- Wages and severance payments
- Pensions and benefits
- Income from self-employment or business
- Income from capital assets
- Rental and leasing income
- Unemployment benefits I
- Citizen’s allowance
- Sick pay

Public health insurance providers don't consider the following earnings when calculating the co-payment limit.

- Child benefit
- Child allowance
- Housing benefit
- Student loans
- Care allowance
- Parental allowance up to 300€
- Integration assistance for disabled people

What allowances are deducted from the income when calculating the co-payment limit?

	2021	2022	2023	2024
For spouses	5,922 €	5,922 €	6,111 €	6,363 €
For each child	8,388 €	8,548 €	8,952 €	9,312€

Source: Finanztip research (as of April 11, 2024)

Example

The table below calculates the co-payment burden limit for a married couple with two children.

Wife's annual gross income	50,000 €
Husband's annual gross income	50,000 €
Total annual gross income	100,000 €
- Spouse allowance	- 6,363 €
- Allowance for 2 children	-18,624 € (9312 x 2)
= family income to be taken into account	75,013 €
Load limit 2%	1500€

In this example, you pay a maximum of around 1500€ in co-payments in 2024. If a family member is chronically ill, the maximum contribution is half, i.e., 750€.

Out-of-pocket-costs in private health insurance

When taking private health insurance, you can decide for a deductible. Deductible is the amount you pay and the health insurance company pays the rest. The higher the deductible the lower the health insurance premium.

However, you shouldn’t take an insurance plan with very high deductible because of the following reasons.

- Reducing deductible later is tough and may require a new health check.
- For employed individuals, your employer contributes to the health insurance premium. However, employer doesn’t contribute to the deductibles. Thus, high deductibles are not advantageous.

Deductible is the major out-of-pocket cost for privately insured individuals. Other out-of-pocket costs depends on your health insurance tariff.

Healthcare coverage

Overview

Public health insurance in Germany covers all the medically necessary treatments. However, the coverage is limited to the treatments that are economical. Usually, the economical treatments are not medically best. So, if you want the best medical coverage in Germany, private health insurance is the answer.

The table below gives you a quick overview of public and private health insurance coverage.

- 💛💛💛**Comprehensive coverage**. You pay very little to nothing for medical services.
- 💛💛🤍**Good coverage.** The health insurer pays part of the costs, and you must bear the rest.
- 💛🤍🤍**Poor coverage.** Little to no costs are covered.

Services	Public health insurance	Private health insurance
Preventive Care and Wellness		
Routine Check-ups and Screenings (cancer screenings, blood tests, etc.)	💛💛🤍	💛💛💛
Vaccinations	💛💛💛	💛💛💛
Mental Health Services	💛💛💛	💛💛🤍 Depends on the plan
Alternative Medicine (Homeopathy, acupuncture, etc.)	💛🤍🤍 (Partially with limits)	💛💛🤍 Depends on the plan
Hospitalization		
Free choice of hospital (Nearest hospital or private clinics)	💛💛🤍 (Nearest hospital)	💛💛💛 (Free choice of hospital)
Accommodation (Shared rooms or private rooms)	💛💛🤍 (Shared room)	💛💛💛 (Private rooms)

Treatment (Doctor at duty or chief doctor)	💛💛🤍 (Doctor on duty)	💛💛💛 (Chief physician)
Dental		
Treatment (Root canal, tooth fillings, etc.)	💛🤍🤍	💛💛💛
Dentures (Implants, inlays, etc.)	💛🤍🤍	💛💛💛
Maternity and Child Healthcare		
Prenatal Care (Regular check-ups, ultrasounds, prenatal screenings, courses, midwife, etc.)	💛💛💛	💛💛💛
Childbirth Options (Give birth at a hospital, birthing centers, or home with midwife assistance)	💛💛🤍	💛💛💛
Postnatal Care (Midwife support, postpartum depression, etc.)	💛💛🤍	💛💛💛
Pediatric coverage (Child's regular checkups, vaccinations, etc.)	💛💛💛	💛💛💛
Chronic disease		
Long-term Care (Care due to chronic conditions or disabilities: at home or in care facilities)	💛💛🤍 Both systems offer the same coverage.	
Rehabilitation Services (Physical therapy, occupational therapy, speech therapy, etc.)		
Home Care Services (Nursing care, assistance with daily activities, medical equipment for home use, etc.)		

Support Groups and Resources (Access to support groups, resources for patients and their families to better understand and cope with the health conditions, etc.)		
Healthcare for Seniors		
Geriatric Care (Regular check-ups, preventive measures, etc.)	💛💛🤍	💛💛💛
Nursing Homes and Assisted Living (Traditional nursing homes, assisted living facilities, shared senior apartments, etc.)	💛💛🤍	💛💛💛
End-of-Life Care (Palliative and hospice care services, pain management, emotional support, etc.)Doctors respect your wishes, which are written in the living will.	💛💛🤍	💛💛💛

What is not covered by health insurance in Germany?

As you may know, medical coverage depends on the type of health insurance: public or private.

What does public health insurance not cover?

- **Cosmetic treatments:** Plastic surgery, laser operation of the eye, etc.
- **Limited dental coverage:** Don't cover high-quality fillings. Partial coverage for other dental treatments.
- **Only economical medical procedures are covered.** For example, it covers only basic chemotherapy. If you want immune system adaptive chemo, you must pay for it yourself. The same applies to other surgeries and inpatient treatments.
- **Alternative medicine:** Public insurance covers only part of the costs of alternative

medicines like homeopath, osteopathy, nature therapy, etc.
- **Travel vaccinations:** This covers the vaccination recommended by STIKO. For other vaccinations, you must pay yourself.

What does private health insurance not cover?

When taking out private health insurance, you can customize your medical coverage. Private health insurance companies are legally required to offer coverage similar to that of public health insurers or better.

We have created a checklist of things your private health insurance must cover. You can download it here for free and use it during your consultation with an insurance broker.

In short, you decide what your private health insurance policy should or shouldn't cover.

Difference between public and private health insurance

Overview

Parameter	Public health insurance	Private health insurance
DOCTOR		
Selection	You can only go to doctors who accept public health insurance.	✅ You have a free choice of doctor selection. You can go to any doctor.
Appointment	It takes 3 to 6 months to get an appointment with a specialist in Germany if you have public insurance.	✅ You can get an appointment within a week or the same day.
Invoice	✅ The insurer settles the invoice directly.	You are responsible for settling the invoice. You submit the invoice to the insurance company, and they usually reimburse you for the costs within a few days.
Drugs	– The patient pays 10% of the prescribed medicine's cost (min. €5, max. €10) – No reimbursement for over-the-counter drugs.	✅ Full reimbursement of all medicines – a deductible may apply. (depending on your tariff)
Psychotherapy	✅ The insurer covers the approved therapy costs ✅ Depending on the treatment, max. 300 sessions	– Whether and to what extent costs are covered depends on the tariff – Usually limited to a few sessions (20 – 30 per year)
Aids / Services (wheelchairs, prostheses, etc.)	The insurer covers the costs of services (aids) mentioned in a directory that is revised regularly.	– Often, a limited catalog of services that are not adopted regularly – Often, the limited scope of reimbursement

Change in medical services	Public health insurance is continuously removing or limiting the medical services it covers.	✅ Private health insurance companies cannot remove or limit the contractually agreed medical services.
HOSPITAL CARE		
Hospital	Admission to the nearest suitable clinic	✅ Free choice of hospital or private clinic possible depending on the tariff
Accommodation	Shared rooms	✅ Private or double rooms, in a few tariffs multi-bed rooms
Treatment	Doctor on duty	✅ Chief physician - Doctor on duty in a few tariffs
COST		
Premium calculation	Premium is calculated based on your income. You pay less if you earn less and pay more if you earn more.	Private health insurance premiums are calculated based on age, existing illnesses, and tariffs. Income doesn't play a role, which is why private insurance is beneficial for high-earners.
Premium increase	Public insurance premiums are increasing at a rate of 3.3% p.a. for the last 10 years.	✅ Private insurance premiums are increasing at a rate of 3.2% p.a. for the last 10 years.
Future outlook	The future of the public healthcare system in Germany doesn't look good. It's because of the aging population and decreasing number of young professionals. Moreover, public system is not prepared for the future.	✅ The private healthcare system is better prepared for the future with an aging provision of 335 billion euros as of July 2024.

DENTIST		
Treatment	– Full assumption of the dental costs of basic care (e.g., amalgam fillings) – Subsidy for more expensive fillings/inlays.	– No restriction to basic service. ✅ Pays 50% to 100% of the costs, depending on the tariff.
Dentures	Pays a subsidy of 60% on the basic service (max. 75%, with a complete bonus booklet). The patient must cover the remaining costs, e.g., for inlays/implants.	✅ Depending on the tariff, the company pays 50% to 100% of the costs. Often with a limit on the sum. ✅ Few tariffs also cover the implant costs.
UNABLE TO WORK		
Sick pay	✅ The insurer pays 70% of your gross income or max. 90% of net income from the 43rd day of sick leave. ✅ The same applies to leaves in the case of a sick child. – Sick pay is limited to 120.75 € per day (as of 2024).	– When and how much the insurer will pay depends on your insurance plan. – The insurer doesn't pay in the case of a sick child. ✅ You can decide on a higher sick pay when concluding the contract
Maternity Protection	– Max. 13 €/day maternity allowance from the health insurance company – The employer tops the maternity allowance to bring it closer to the net salary. – Special rules for voluntarily insured persons.	Max. 210 € maternity benefit from the "Federal Insurance Office" depending on the tariff
Maternity leave	✅ You don't have to pay insurance premiums during maternity leave.	Usually, you pay monthly insurance contributions during maternity leave.
SWITCHING INSURANCE		

Changing health insurance provider	✅ You can change public health insurance providers anytime without consequences.	Changing a private health insurance provider is expensive. Even changing your health insurance plan with the same provider can be expensive.
Switching between private and public insurance	✅ If you meet the eligibility criteria, you can switch to private health insurance anytime.	Returning to public health insurance is tough, even if you are unemployed or earn below 69,300 € (as of 2024).
IN THE EVENT OF DISPUTE		
Cost to sue the insurance company	✅ You can object to the health insurer's decision free of charge.	No legally regulated right to object. You must go to an insurance ombudsman or hire a lawyer.
Legal costs	✅ Court and lawyers' fees are not based on the value in dispute but are limited by law.	Legal costs depend on the value in dispute. Thus, you may incur higher costs.
If you lose the dispute	✅ You bear only your legal costs. You don't pay the legal costs of the insurance company.	You bear your and your insurance company's legal costs if you lose the dispute in court.

Private health insurance pros and cons

Pros	Cons
Civil servants and self-employed (high-earners) can save between 250 € and 500 € per month with private health insurance.	Private health insurance is expensive for families where only one partner earns. It's because you cannot insure your non-working spouse and children for free in private health insurance.

You get better medical services with private health insurance	Returning to the public healthcare system is difficult and becomes impossible after 55.
Private insurance members get a specialist's appointment within a week or the same day.	Changing private health insurance companies is expensive. You lose around 30% of your retirement provisions when you change the insurance provider.
Dental coverage in private health insurance is better than in public.	Private health insurance companies have the right to choose their customers. Thus, they reject unhealthy applicants.
High earners pay less premiums for private insurance than for public insurance.	If private health insurance must accept an unhealthy customer, they offer basic plans or charge high premiums.
The private health insurance premium for high-earners in old age is usually lower than that of public health insurance.	You must join private health insurance when young to build up retirement provisions. If you join private insurance in the old age, your premiums will be very high.
The private healthcare system is better prepared for the future. It has saved a retirement provision of 335 billion euros as of July 2024. The insurer uses the retirement provision to keep the insurance premium stable in old age.	You must continue to pay private health insurance premiums during maternity leave.

We recommend consulting an insurance broker or a fee-based adviser for personalized advice before taking private health insurance in Germany. Insurance brokers and advisors are liable for their advice. This means that if the insurance plan they recommended doesn't fulfill your wishes, they are liable to pay the damages.

Insurance brokers offer free advice. The insurance company pays them upon the successful conclusion of the contract. An insurance broker can also help you file a claim with the provider. You can book a call with the insurance broker we recommend here.

Public health insurance pros and cons

Pros	Cons
Every member of public health insurance enjoys the same medical services irrespective of their insurance premium.	Unlike private health insurance, public health insurance offers basic services only.
Public health insurance premiums depend on income. So, low-earners pay less premium than high-earners.	Because the public insurance premium depends on your income, it's expensive for high earners.
Anyone can join public health insurance. People who earn lower than the income threshold (69,300 € as of 2024) are compulsorily insured in public insurance. And high earners can voluntarily join the public system.	Dental coverage is very basic in public health insurance. You must get a supplementary dental insurance policy to cover the costs of dental treatment.
You can insure your non-working spouse and children for free under your public health insurance.	Getting a specialist appointment can take months for public health insurance members.
You can insure yourself for free under your spouse's public health insurance during parental or maternity leave.	

How do you access healthcare in Germany?

How do you find a doctor in Germany?

- **Google search**
- **Call your health insurance provider** for support in finding and scheduling a doctor's appointment.
- **Appointment booking platforms:** Doctolib, Jameda, Zava, and Doctena.
- **Dentist**: Official government website to find dentists. You must go to your federal state's website to search for dentists.

Many doctors don't accept new patients in big cities like Berlin, Stuttgart, etc. The situation is even worse for pediatricians (Kinderartz). In such scenarios, your health insurance company can help you find one.

> **NOTE**: The problem of getting a doctor's appointment applies to individuals insured in statutory health insurance. Privately insured people get appointments within a day or week.

How do you pay for the medical services in Germany?

	Public health insurance	**Private health insurance**
Doctor visit	Show your health insurance card to access the service without paying a cent.	You pay first and get reimbursed
Pharmacy	Pay a small amount or nothing	
Dental services	Pay the invoice amount after deducting health insurance subsidies	
Other services, such as physiotherapy		

Hospitals	Show your health insurance card to access the service without paying a cent. If you access services not covered by your health insurer, you'll recieve an invoice.

How do you access health services in Germany?

	Do you need an appointment?	How long it takes to get an appointment?
Family doctor	No (You should call the clinic before going)	Same day or the next day
Specialist	Yes	**Private health insurance:** within a week. **Public health insurance:** 4 to 8 months
Dentist	Yes	Depends on your location and urgency. It's easy to get a dentist appointment in Germany.
Hospitals	No	You can go directly to the hospital in an emergency. The waiting time depends on the patient's health condition.

Family Doctors (Hausartz)

When you are ill or have a medical problem, your first point of contact is your family doctor (Hausartz in German). Usually, you don't need an appointment to visit, but always confirm this with your doctor.

Specialists in Germany

If you require a specialist's consultation, your family doctor will write a transfer order (Überweisung). You must make an appointment.

- **Statutory health insurance members** wait 4 to 8 months for an appointment. They need an Überweisung.

- **Private health insurance members** can get an appointment on the same day or week. They don't need an Überweisung.

Dentists in Germany

You must get an appointment. You get a dentist appointment faster than other specialists.

- **Public health insurance** covers basic dental care. So, locals get supplementary dental insurance to cover dental costs.
- **Good private health insurance** plans offer comprehensive coverage with 70% to 90% coverage of dental costs.

There are 36,320 dental clinics in Germany as of 2023 [7]. The majority of them are private clinics run by individuals.

Hospitals in Germany (Krankenhaus)

You can go to any hospital for treatment. Every hospital in Germany has an emergency area that is open 24/7.

There are 1893 hospitals in Germany as of 2022 run by the government, private, and NGOs. [6]

- **Number of public hospitals** (Öffentliche Krankenhäuser): 539
- **Number of private hospitals** (Privat Krankenhäuser): 756
- **Number of hospitals run by NGOs** (Freigemeinnützige Krankenhäuser): 598

Need medical advice outside normal working hours

You can call the patient service at "**116 117**" for medical advice 24/7. They also offer advice via chat.

Medical emergency

A medical emergency is an injury or illness that poses an immediate risk to a person's life or long-term health. In a medical emergency, you should call "**112**" (valid all across Europe).

Pharmacies in Germany (Apotheke)

Pharmacies are open from 08:00 to 18:00 (Monday to Friday) and 08:00 to 12:00 (Saturday). Some pharmacies are open longer and even on Sundays.

You can also buy medicine online on websites such as Shop Apotheke, Apodiscounter, etc.

- **Over-the-counter (OTC) drugs:** You don't need a doctor's prescription. You pay for it yourself. Public health insurance doesn't cover the costs, but good private health insurance tariffs do.
- **Prescribed medicine:** You need a doctor's prescription. Your health insurance policy covers the costs. However, you may have to pay 5€ to 10€ if you have public health insurance.

Navigating the German healthcare system as an expat

Language Barriers and Translation Services

Doctors and medical staff usually speak German. In big cities, it's easier to find English-speaking doctors. If you don't speak German, you should bring a friend or relative who can be an interpreter.

Currently, health insurance companies don't reimburse the translator's costs. [1] However, the government has proposed that health insurance should cover it. [2]

Cultural differences in medical treatment

German doctors are more direct in their communication style, emphasize natural remedies, and avoid prescribing medicines whenever possible. In many cultures, patients expect to get medication to relieve pain when visiting a doctor. Don't expect it in Germany.

Additionally, don't be surprised if your doctor in Germany scolds you for doing something stupid.

Patient Rights and Responsibilities

You have the same rights as German citizens in the healthcare system. You have the right to choose your doctor and access your medical records.

Complaints and Dispute Resolution

In case of disputes with your doctor or medical staff, you can file a complaint with your health insurance provider or the medical association of your federal state. You even have the right to sue the doctor. You need a lawyer to take matters to the court. You can get legal insurance to cover the lawyer and court fees.

Sick leave

This chapter is relevant if you are employed or self-employed during your studies.

After a severe injury like a broken arm or a car accident, work is the last thing you think about. But still, you need money to put food on the table. In Germany, as an employee, you don't have to worry about your finances during your recovery time. Your employer continues to pay you a full salary for the first six weeks. After that, the health insurance company steps in with the sick pay.

Germans prefer to stay at home when they are sick. They believe it's better to recover 100% than drag the sickness for long. Also, when you are sick, you cannot work efficiently and risk infecting your colleagues. Thus, stay home until recovered.

Who is entitled to sick pay?

- Employees insured with public health insurance.
- Self-employed who pay the normal public health insurance contributions, i.e., 14.6% (as of 2024).
- All privately insured individuals whose plan offers sickness benefits.

> **NOTE**: Whether privately insured people receive sick pay depends on their contract. The contract determines how much and from when you'll receive the sick pay.

Self-employed people must take care of their sick pay themselves

Unlike employees, self-employed people must take care of their income when sick themselves. You have two options:

1. Like employees, you take sickness benefit insurance from your public health insurer. In this case, you'll get sickness benefits after 6 weeks of illness.
2. You can take out private daily sickness benefits insurance (Krankentagegeldversicherung). In this case, your policy determines when and how much sick pay you'll get.

Who doesn't get sick pay?

The following people are not entitled to sickness benefits.

- Spouses and children who are insured for free in family health insurance.
- Interns
- Students
- Recipients of unemployment benefit II (Arbeitslosengeld II). If you draw unemployment benefit II (aka Hartz IV), you'll continue to receive basic security during your sick days.

In certain cases, the health insurance company can suspend your entitlement to sick pay. For example, you won't receive sick pay during parental leave. Instead, you'll get parental benefits.

When do you get sick pay?

If you are eligible for sick pay, you'll get it in the following situations (§ 5 Para. 1 No. 1 SGB V).

- You do not receive a salary from your employer and are getting treatment as an inpatient in a hospital or rehabilitation facility.
- You cannot work for more than six weeks due to the same illness, and your employer no longer pays (§ 3 Continued Pay Act).
- You started a new job and got sick in the first four weeks. In this situation, your employer does not have to pay your salary. Instead, the health insurance company pays you sick pay.
- You receive unemployment benefit 1 (Arbeitslosengeld 1) and are ill for more than six weeks. The Employment Agency (Agentur für Arbeit) continues to pay unemployment

benefits for the first six weeks. After that, the health insurance company takes over to pay sickness benefits.

You must get a certificate of incapacity for work (Arbeitsunfähigkeitsbescheinigung) from a doctor within a week. Otherwise, the health insurance company will not pay the sick pay. And worst, you may lose your entitlement to sick pay (Section 49 (1) No. 5 SGB V).

What should you consider when getting sick notice from the doctor?

The entitlement to paid sick leave begins when your doctor determines that you cannot work (Section 46 sentence 1 no. 2 SGB V). Normally, doctors in Germany do not issue sick notes (Arbeitsunfähigkeitsbescheinigung) for long periods.

Thus, your doctor must issue a new sick note from the day your last sick note ended to maintain your entitlement to sick pay.

For example, your sick leave ends on Tuesday. Then, you have to see the doctor by Wednesday. Otherwise, there will be a gap in the period you were ill. And it may lead the health insurance company to stop your sick pay.

However, since 2016, the doctor's note for sick leaves don't have to overlap. As a result, fewer people lose their entitlement to paid sick leave due to formal errors.

The gap in sick leave

As a rule, your doctor cannot give you a backdated sick leave certificate. However, there may be exceptions. For example, you contacted your doctor well in time and booked an appointment. But the doctor postponed the meeting. Then, the doctor can write you a sick leave certificate for up to three days in the past. With this backdated medical certificate, you

won't lose your entitlement to sick pay (as per the judgment on March 26, 2020, Az. B 3 KR 10/19 R).

The German government also introduced a special regulation by the Appointment Service and Care Act. Under this act, you have one month to get a new sick note after the last sick leave ends. And during this time, you will continue to receive the sickness benefits.

Don't know when you'll be able to work?

There is a field on the medical certificate in which the doctor must enter how long you will be unable to work. The doctor usually issues the sick leave certificate for no more than two weeks. But if the end of the disease is not yet foreseeable, some doctors leave this field empty. And others write "**until further notice (bis auf Weiteres).**"

The best part is that health insurance companies must continue paying for sickness benefits.

What do you have to do to get sick pay?

You do **not have to submit a separate application** to receive sick pay. Here is what the process looks like:

1. The employer sends proof of earnings to your health insurance company

Your health insurance company will request an "earnings certificate"(Verdienstbescheinigung) from your employer at the end of six weeks. It uses the earnings certificate to calculate your sick pay.

Under German law, the employer must send all the required information to your health insurer to calculate your sick pay.

2. Get a sick note from your doctor

Since 2016 there is a single document, sick note (Arbeitsunfähigkeitsbescheinigung), that you can use for both sick leave and sick pay.

The doctor certifies your incapacity to work on the document. Then, you submit this document to your employer to take sick leaves until you are fit and have sick pay for six weeks. You submit the same document to your health insurance company. And after six weeks, you become eligible to get the sickness benefits.

3. Submit the “incapacity for work” certificate

You are responsible for making sure that your insurer gets the certificate on time. But, since October 2021, your doctor should send the certificate of incapacity to work to your statutory health insurance company electronically.

However, many medical practices do not have the necessary technology. Thus, they continue to give the certificate in paper form.

If your doctor cannot submit the certificate to your health insurance, you must send it yourself. You can submit the certificate online, via mobile app, or by registered mail.

4. Verification and payment of sickness benefits

You will receive sick pay as soon as your health insurance company receives and processes the “incapacity for work” certificate. The insurance company pays the sickness benefit in retrospect to the first day of your incapacity to work. The doctor mentions your first day of illness in the sick note.

5. Send a sick note to your employer

Send a sick note to your employer as soon as you get one. It is required by the employer to pay you a full salary for the first six weeks. You should continue informing your employer after six weeks about your illness.

Even if the employer no longer pays the salary, they need to know if and when you can work again. If you are unemployed and receive unemployment benefits I (ALG I), you must inform the employment agency.

How much is sick pay in Germany?

According to German law, sick pay is 70 percent of gross earnings but no more than 90 percent of net earnings (Section 47 SGB V). So, the lower of these two values is the gross sick pay.

The health insurance company deducts social security from the gross sick pay and pays the rest. You can use sick pay calculator by TK to calculate the net sick pay.

Example of sick pay calculation

Item	Amount (Monthly)
Gross Salary	3000 €
Net Salary (Income tax class III, 1 Child)	1977 €
70% of the gross salary	2100 €
90% of the net salary	1779 €
Gross sick pay	1779 €
Social Security	
Pension Insurance (9,3 %) (Rentenversicherung)	165 €
Unemployment Insurance (1,20 %) (Arbeitslosenversicherung)	21 €
Long-term Care Insurance (1,525 %) (Pflegeversicherung)	27 €
Net sick pay	**1557 €**

The insurance company also considers one-time payments like Christmas (Weinachtsgeld) or Holidays (Uralubsgeld) allowance while calculating the sick pay (Section 47 (2) sentence 6 SGB V). These one-time payments increase the amount of sick pay you will get.

Sick pay for high earners

The law limits the amount of sick pay to 70 percent of the contribution assessment ceiling (Beitragsbemessungsgrenze). As a result, you can get a maximum of 120.75 € gross sick pay per day in 2024 or 3622.5 € per month.

Net sick pay is not enough to cover your expenses.

You may need more than the sick pay if you are a high earner and have high monthly expenses. In this situation, you can take private sick pay insurance (Krankengeldversicherung) to cover the difference.

Another option is to ask your employer. Some employers in Germany supplement sick pay to cover the difference in your net salary and net sick pay.

How long is the paid sick leave period?

You can avail sickness benefits for **78 weeks within three years** per illness (§ 48 SGB V). You don't have to be on continuous sick leave; the health insurance company adds the periods you were ill.

However, the waiting period of six weeks occurs only once in these three years. And as you already know, you receive wages from your employer during this time.

Here are some rules that apply when you are on paid sick leave

- You will receive sick pay immediately if you get additional sick leave due to the same illness.

- The same rule applies if you are self-employed and are entitled to sick pay. However, some health insurance companies do not follow this rule. So, discuss it with your health insurance partner before signing the contract.
- The health insurance company will not extend the sickness benefit period if you catch another illness during your sick leave. The benefit period will remain the same, i.e., 78 weeks (§ 48 Para. 1 Sentence 2 SGB V).
- 78 weeks of sickness benefit period includes the sick leave paid by your employer. That means the first six weeks; your employer pays you the wages. And the health insurance company covers the rest of the period, i.e., 72 weeks (§ 49 Para . 1 No. 1 SGB V, § 146 Para . 1 Clause 1 SGB III).
- You don't get sick pay during parental leave, as you get parental allowance during that period.

What happens if you catch the same sickness after three years?

After three years, everything starts anew. So, if you catch the same illness in a new three-year period, your sickness benefits start over again.

But, you must fulfill the following conditions to receive sickness benefits.

- You must be in the statutory health insurance scheme.
- You must either be employed or be looking for a job.
- No doctor gave you sick leave for the same disease for at least six months.

Is sick pay tax-free?

The answer to this question is yes and no.

Yes, you don't pay taxes on sick pay. However, it is subject to the progression proviso. This means, the tax office adds the sickness benefit to the total taxable income of that year to determine your tax rate.

This way the tax office ensures fair tax calculation for people who received sick pay and those who didn't. Hence, people who received sickness benefits may not have a lower tax rate than people who didn't.

Resolving trouble with your health insurance company?

It is your right to receive paid sick leave. But your health insurance company can get in the way. So, it's essential to know how you can defend yourself against common problems:

Unsolicited calls from health insurance

Patient advice centers (Beratungsstelle) report that many insured people feel pressured by their health insurance company on the phone. Sometimes, health insurance companies advise their customers to quit their jobs and apply for unemployment benefits.

One of the motivations behind this suggestion is health insurers don't have to pay sickness benefits if you register yourself as unemployed. But you should never respond to such suggestions.

In principle, the health insurance company can call you for individual advice on sick pay. But only if they have your written consent. And you can revoke your consent at any time (§ 44 Para. 4 SGB V).

If you feel harassed by your health insurance company, feel free to tell them that you do not want telephone advice. Also, mention that you are happy to answer any necessary questions in writing only.

Please note that you have certain obligations to cooperate (§ 60 to 67 SGB I) with the health insurer. So you cannot refuse to provide information. However, you can provide the required information in writing instead of on the telephone.

Get your health checked by “Medizinischen Dienst.”

“Medizinischen Dienst” checks your incapacity to work, not the health insurance company.

So, your health insurance company can request “Medizinischen Dienst” to check your incapacity to work. However, in this check, your insurer can ask only these two questions (in writing):

1. Is it possible to know by when you can work again? If yes, what is the tentative date?
2. Are there any treatments planned that prevent you from returning to work?

You can also agree to provide this information by telephone. But in this case, the health insurance company must create a protocol for the call.

There could be situations when you are unsure what to tell the health insurance company. In such scenarios, you can contact an advice center (Beratungsstelle) for guidance.

Every city has multiple advice centers run by NGOs or the government. You can find them by searching “Beratungsstelle” on Google.

The health insurance company issues a letter to stop paying sickness benefits.

The health insurance company can tell you they’ll stop paying the sick pay as you are healthy and can work. Many people in Germany have received such a letter.

But, to issue this letter, the insurance company needs the expert opinion of the medical service (Medizinischen Dienst). The Medical Service (M.D.) judges your health based on your medical reports. However, they may also ask for a personal examination in exceptional cases.

But, an assessment based on the medical records alone does not always hold in court. In a similar situation, the Hessische Landessozialgericht (State Social Court) ruled in favor of a civil engineer.

As per its ruling, the health insurance company must conduct extensive investigations into the state of health before it stops paying sickness benefits.

The ruling applies especially in the case of a mental illness. Thus, the health insurance company should conduct your examination before concluding anything.

On top of it, they must request your medical records from your doctor to learn more about your health condition (judgment of October 18, 2007, Az. L 8 KR 228/06).

What can you do if the health insurance company wants to stop paying sick pay?

If the insurer wants to stop paying sick pay, you should do the following.

- Request the M.D.'s report as soon as possible.
- File an objection within one month to the health insurance company. Add the note that you will submit the reason for the objection later, for example, within 14 days after you have received the M.D.'s report.
- Ask your physician to apply for a second opinion from the health insurance company (§ 6 Disability Directive).

But your doctor might refuse to apply for a second opinion. In this case, list all the doctors who can treat you in your objection letter and add a note:

"for the medical justification of the objection, please contact the doctors mentioned in the list."

If the health insurance company contacts any of the doctors from your list for an opinion, doctors are legally bound to answer. Of course, they can bill the health insurance company for their service.

Many times the second opinion changes the decision of the health insurer. And you continue to receive the sickness benefits.

You should apply for rehab

The health insurance company may ask you to apply for rehabilitation via your pension insurance. The German law allows health insurers to do this if they believe you are at risk of disability (§ 51 Para. 1 SGB V).

Here are a few things that you should know about applying for rehab.

- As per law, you have ten weeks to submit your rehab application. And the health insurance company cannot set a shorter deadline.
- We recommend sending the rehab application by registered mail, as it proves that you applied on time.
- It's vital to send the rehabilitation application within ten weeks, as the insurance company may stop paying sick pay.
- You have the right to appeal against the request for rehabilitation.
- If in doubt, contact an advice center near you for guidance.
- You have the freedom to choose the rehab center.
- During rehabilitation, you will not receive sick pay but a transitional allowance (Übergangsgeld in German).
- Transitional allowance is paid by your pension insurance when you are in rehab. It is 68 percent of the last net salary if you have no kids and 75 percent if you do.

- The paid sick leave continues if you are unable to work after rehab.

But, if the physician determines that you cannot work long-term, your rehab application will convert into a disability pension application. Once the disability application is approved, you will no longer receive sick pay.

Vacation is allowed when you are on paid sick leave

German law allows you to go on vacation when you are on paid sick leave. But the holiday should not impair your recovery.

You don't need the health insurance company's approval to go on a vacation as long as you travel within Germany. But, if you decide to travel outside of Germany, you will need your insurer's approval. However, according to the Federal Social Court ruling, health insurance companies must approve the travel if it's within E.U. (Az. B 3 KR 23/18 R). At least in most cases.

Things to do if you plan to travel abroad during paid sick leave.

- Get a note from your physician stating the trip will not interfere with your recovery.
- Inform your health insurance company several weeks before the trip.

By applying early, you'll have the time to file an objection if your insurer does not approve your travel.

Get help from a counseling center

You should take help from the advice center when in need. They can help you with the following.

- Resolving conflicts with your health insurance company.
- Explain your rights.

- Guide you based on the situation.
- Help you write an objection against the health insurer.

Here are some of the entities that provide counseling.

- Independent patient advice service (UPD)
- Consumer advice centers
- Social organizations such as the VDK.

Take legal action if the objection is unsuccessful

If your objection is unsuccessful, you can still take legal action before the social court. The German government waived the court fees to make it easier for the general public to take legal action. However, it makes sense to get help from a lawyer specializing in social law.

You have to pay the fee of the lawyer yourself if you lose the case. So weigh the cost before taking any legal action, especially if you don't have legal insurance (Rechanwaltsversicherung in German).

What happens after paid sick leave ends?

The following applies if you cannot work after 78 weeks of paid sick leaves.

- You won't get sick pay after the 78th week.
- You may be entitled to a disability pension (Erwerbsminderungsrente in German).
- Your health insurance company will ask you to apply for medical rehabilitation. The insurer must do so no later than three months before your sickness benefits expire.

The doctor checks whether rehab can restore your ability to work within three to six months. If it can't, your application for rehabilitation converts into a disability pension application.

German pension bureau may take months to evaluate your application for a disability pension. So your sickness benefits may expire before you start receiving a disability pension.

Hence, you should inform the employment agency also about your condition at least three months before your sick leave ends. This way, you can claim unemployment benefits (§ 145 SBG III) until you get a disability pension.

Child sickness benefits

This chapter is relevant if you are employed or self-employed during your studies.

Child sickness benefits (Kinderkrankengeld in German) are the benefits you receive when your child falls sick. The benefits you receive are

- leave from your work (up to 15 days per child)
- child sick pay for the days you didn't work (90% of the lost net wages)

Legal basis of child sickness benefits

As per the Civil Code (§ 616 BGB), employees are entitled to paid time off if they cannot work for a personal reason. The personal reason can be taking care of a sick child.

The legal definition of paid time off is that the employer continues to pay the wages when the employee is on leave. However, many employers in Germany exclude this right to paid time off via collective agreement or employment contract. It is when your health insurance company steps in to cover the lost wages.

You have the right to unpaid time off per Section 45 SGB V. It doesn't matter if your employer doesn't paid for the time off.

This means you can take unpaid leaves when your child is sick. Moreover, you are entitled to receive child sick pay (Kinderkrankengeld in German) from your statutory health insurance provider. The sick pay from the health insurer is also called wage replacement.

Who can claim child sickness benefits?

Whether you get child sickness benefits depends on your

- health insurance,
- employment status, and
- child's health insurance

Public health insurance

To receive child sick pay from the public insurer, both the parent and child must be insured with public health insurance or part of family insurance.

- **Employees**: Every employee insured with statutory health insurance can apply for child sick pay.
- **Self-employed**: The self-employed also receive child sickness benefits. The prerequisite is opting for sick pay when signing the health insurance contract.
- **Mini Job**: Parents working in mini-jobs usually don't receive child sick pay from the public insurer. However, you are entitled to unpaid leave to look after your child.
- **Working part-time while receiving parental allowance:** You are entitled to sick pay. Moreover, receiving child sick pay doesn't affect your parental allowance. You'll continue to receive parental allowance as before.
- **Unemployed**: Unemployed people don't receive sick child pay.

Private health insurance

Private health insurance companies usually don't offer child sickness benefits. However, you can opt for child sick pay while signing the contract. Suppose your current private health insurance plan doesn't cover child sick pay. You can also change your private health insurance tariff.

Requirements you must fulfill to receive child sick pay

- You don't get paid time off from your employer to care for the sick child.

- The child for whom you are claiming sickness benefits must be younger than 12. Children with disabilities have no age limits.
- The child must live in the same household. Of course, if the child is seriously ill and must be hospitalized, this rule doesn't apply.
- You need a sick note from a doctor to prove your child is ill.
- No one else in the household can take care of the child. For example, if the child's grandparents live in the same household, they can care for your child. In this case, you don't receive child sick pay.

How do you apply for child sickness benefits?

- Inform your employer immediately that your child is sick and you cannot work as you must care for the child at home.
- You should also inform the child's daycare or school.
- Get a doctor's certificate, also called "Muster 21." You can get it from your child's pediatrician (Kinderartz in German).
- The sick note also contains the application form for child sickness benefits. It's usually on the back of the sick note or down below.
- Fill out the application form. Sign it and send a copy to your employer.
- You must send the original doctor's certificate to the health insurance company. You can also submit the doctor's certificate online on your health insurer's website or mobile app.
- You need to fill out the following information on the application form.
    - Your bank details

    - Whether you'll receive wages from your employer
    - Are you a single parent?
    - Number of child sick days you have already taken in the current year.
- The health insurance company also needs proof of income to calculate the sick pay. Your employer will send it directly to your health insurer. So, you don't have to do anything here.

> **NOTE:** Since 18 December 2023, you can get a sick note for your child on the phone. Hence saving you the visit to the doctor with a sick child.

However, there are some limitations to getting the doctor's certificate by phone.

- The maximum number of sick days you can get on the telephone is five.
- Your child must be registered with the doctor's practice.

The doctor's office emails you the sick note or asks you to pick it up from the practice.

How many days of child sickness benefits can you receive?

Since 2024, the number of days parents can take time off work to care for a sick child has increased. Here is the number of child sick days you can take in 2024 and 2025.

Families with two parents

- Families with one or two children can take 15 working days off per child and parent in a year.
    - **One child:** up to 30 days off per year as a family.
    - **Two children**: up to 60 days off per year as a family.

- Families with more than two children can take up to 35 working days off per parent.
    - **More than two children:** up to 70 working days in a year as a family.

Single parents

- **One child:** up to 30 working days off in a year.
- **Two children:** up to 60 working days off in a year.
- **More than two children:** up to 70 working days off in a year.

What applies if the child is admitted to the hospital?

As per the Nursing Study Strengthening Act (Pflegestudiumstärkungsgesetz), you'll receive child sickness benefits if admitted to the hospital with the sick child. The health insurer will pay you the child sickness benefits as long as you are in the hospital. There is no maximum number of child sick days in this scenario.

Moreover, the days in the hospital don't count towards the regular child sick days. To be eligible for these benefits, you must fulfill the following conditions.

- The admission to the hospital is medically necessary. If the child is up to 8 years old, it's assumed that admission is medically necessary.
- Your child is under 12 years old or has a disability.

The hospital or the inpatient facility certifies that the hospital admission was medically necessary and for how long.

What applies if your child is terminally ill?

You can take unlimited child sick days if your child is terminally ill and is expected to have a few weeks or months left.

How much is the child sick pay?

- As per Section 45 Para. 2 SGB V, you receive 90 percent of your lost net salary as gross child sickness benefit.
- There is a cap on the maximum child sick pay one can receive. The maximum child sick pay is 120.75 € per day as of 2024.
- You must also pay the social security contributions on your child sick pay. The social security contribution is 12.3% for employees with one child.
- The health insurer deducts social security contributions from child sickness benefits and pays the remaining amount.

Sickness benefits in case your child meets with an accident

Suppose your child met with an accident in kindergarten, after-school care, at school, or on the way to school or home. In this case, the statutory accident insurance pays the sickness benefit. The child sick pay or injury benefit is 80% of your net salary. You apply for the injury benefit via your health insurance company.

Do you have to declare child sick pay in the income tax returns?

Yes, you must declare the child sick pay you received during the year in the income tax return. Moreover, you are legally bound to file an income tax return if you received more than 410 € of child sick pay.

Although the child sick pay is tax-free, but it's added to your gross income to find the right tax rate. It's possible that by adding the child sickness benefits, your tax rate may increase.

Your health insurance company also sends you a letter stating the total child sickness benefits you received in the year for tax purposes.

Family health insurance

Only relevant if you bring your family to Germany to live with you during your studies.

If you meet certain criteria, you can insure your family members for free under your public health insurance. In this case, your family members' health insurance is called family health insurance (Familienversicherung in German).

If you have private health insurance, you **cannot** insure your dependents for free. You must get a separate private health insurance policy for your children and non-working spouse.

What are the requirements for free family insurance?

Here are the requirements your family members must meet to be insured for **free** in your public health insurance.

- The family member to be insured must live in Germany.
- They do not work full-time as self-employed.
- The family member must not be exempt from public insurance.
- People from certain professional groups, such as civil servants, judges, soldiers, or clergy, cannot be included in family insurance.
- Their monthly income doesn't exceed the minimum income limit. The income limit is 505 € per month as of 2024.
- The income shouldn't exceed the mini-job income limit for family members working part-time. It's 538 € per month as of 2024.

TIP: You can exceed the income limits up to twice a year.

For example, suppose you earned 550 € in August and September each. And for other months, your income was below the income limit. In this case, you remain insured for free in

family health insurance. But if you exceed the income limit more than twice a year, you must pay for health insurance.

> **NOTE**: Only people part of the public health insurance system can insure their families for free in family insurance. People with private health insurance must get a private insurance policy for their relatives.

We find TK the best public health insurance provider for expats. It offers its website, mobile app, and customer support in English. You can register with TK online here.

Who can be insured under family health insurance for free in Germany?

The following people can have a free public health insurance plan if they meet the requirements.

- Spouses or life partners
- Both spouses or life partners can remain insured in family insurance until the divorce is finalized, even if they live separately.
- Children can be insured for free in public insurance up to 18. It also applies to foster and stepchildren. You can also insure your grandchildren if you primarily support them. You can even insure your child up to 23 for free if they are not employed. And up to 25 if they are in training or studying.
- If the training is interrupted by military service, voluntary service, or work as a development worker, an extension of twelve months is possible.
- Children who cannot look after themselves due to a disability remain insured for free in family insurance for an unlimited period.

> **NOTE**: Suppose you earn more than the income limit as a student. In this case, you cannot be insured in free family insurance. Always contact your public insurer before getting a part-time job during your studies.

How do you apply for free family health insurance?

- Fill out the form “Fragenbogen die Aufnahme in die Familienversicherung.”
- Submit the form and the requested documents to your public health insurance provider.

Your public insurer will validate the form and the documents. If everything is fine, your insurance company will send a confirmation letter and a health insurance card (only if your family member doesn’t have one).

Nowadays, you can do the whole process online on your public insurer’s website. You must log in to the insurer’s portal and search for the form.

What are the income limits to get free family health insurance in Germany?

The income limit depends on the type of employment. Here are the income limits for the common professions.

Regular employees

A regular Employee is one who works on a full-time or part-time basis on regularly scheduled shifts of a continuing nature. The income limit is 505 € per month if your family member is a regular employee. However, the family member can deduct income-related expenses or the flat rate amount from their gross income.

Hence, the income limit increases from 505 € to 607.5 € per month. The amount is calculated by adding the income limit of 505 € and the flat rate for income-related expenses of 1,230 € per year (102.50 € per month).

Suppose your family member has higher income-related expenses than the flat rate. In this case, the income limit can be higher (income limit plus income-related expenses).

Self-employed

The income limit for self-employed family members is 505 € per month. However, they should be self-employed part-time to qualify for free family health insurance.

The income considered for health insurance is the profit from self-employment.

Mini job

Your family members can be insured free of charge if they earn up to 538 € a month in a mini job.

What do the insurer consider as income for family insurance?

- Income from wages and salaries.
- Profits from business.
- Income from renting and leasing.
- Pension payments
- Interest and dividend income from investments.
- Capital gains from selling the investments.

Expenses you can deduct from your income

You can deduct the following allowances and expenses to reduce your income.

- The saver allowance of 1000 € from the capital income, such as dividends, interest, capital gains, etc.
- Income-related expenses or a flat rate of 1230€ as of 2024.

What to do if your income exceeds the income limit later?

You must inform your public health insurance provider once your total income exceeds the income limit. If you keep the change in income secret, the health insurance company will terminate your family insurance retroactively. Moreover, they may demand additional contributions.

When can you not insure your children for free in family insurance?

In the following cases, children cannot be insured for free in family health insurance.

- Both parents have private health insurance.
- One parent has private health insurance, and the other has public. In this case, the child cannot be insured with free family insurance if the parents meet all the conditions below.
    - The parents are married or life partners under the Civil Partnership Act.
    - The privately insured parent earns more than the publicly insured parent.

- The total monthly income of the privately insured parent exceeds the annual salary limit (5,775 euros per month gross as of 2024).

What happens when family insurance ends?

Once your child is older than 25, they must get their own health insurance. Children older than 25 have the following options.

- If your child is a student, they can take discounted student health insurance. However, discounted student health insurance is for children who are below 30.
- Students who are 30 or above should get a regular health insurance policy. They can choose between private or public health insurance.
- Children who have full-time jobs must get a regular health insurance policy. They can choose between private or public health insurance depending on their income.

Student health insurance via public insurer costs around 115 € per month, plus the additional contribution. As of 2024, the average additional contribution is 1.7%. Hence, students pay around 129 € per month in health insurance premiums.

Public health insurance: We find TK the best public health insurer for expats in Germany. You can register with TK online here.

Private health insurance: You must get private health insurance via an insurance broker. You can book a free call with the insurance broker we recommend here.

Best public health insurance companies

We find TK to be the best public health insurance company for expats in Germany. If you can speak German, HKK is also a good option.

TK and HKK both are one of the cheapest public health insurance companies in Germany as of 2024. You can register with TK online here.

How did we find the best public health insurance provider in Germany?

We considered the following parameters when comparing the public health insurance companies.

- Digital services
- English customer care, website, and mobile app
- Monthly premium
- Difference in the services offered
    - Dental services
    - Homeopathy
    - Osteopathy
    - Glasses
    - Sports

We found little difference in the services public health insurance companies offered compared to TK. However, we found significant differences in their digital offerings and English customer support.

Additionally, certain public health insurance premiums are significantly higher than TK's.

Comparison of public health insurance services

Parameter	HKK	TK (Our Choice)
Summary	➖ Second cheapest insurer as of Aug 2024 ➖ Offers digital services ➖ Offers basic English support	➖ Competitively priced insurance as of Aug 2024 ✅ Best insurer in digital service offerings ✅ Best insurer in English support
Premium	Additional contribution (Zusatzbeitrag): 0.98%	Additional contribution (Zusatzbeitrag): 1.2%
🇬🇧 **English Support**	💛 💛 🤍	💛 💛 💛
Website	Only in German	✅ Few parts of the website are in English
Mobile App	Only in German Play Store rating: 4.6 rated by 6.81k users App Store rating: 4.0 rated by 1 user	✅ Parts of the app are in English Play Store rating: 4.5 rated by 111k users App Store rating: 4.8 rated by 854 user
Customer Service	German and English Expect longer waiting times for customer support in English	✅ Good English customer care support.
🦷 **Dental**	💛 💛 🤍	💛 💛 🤍
Professional cleaning	Free teeth cleaning at certain dentists	Up to €40/year
Supplementary dental insurance Get dental insurance to cover dental treatment costs that are not covered by public health insurance.		
🤰 **Pregnancy**	💛 💛 🤍	💛 💛 🤍

Screening tests	Up to 300€ ✅ Chickenpox antibody test ✅ Fifth disease antibody test ✅ Strep antibody test ✅ Toxoplasmosis test ✅ chickenpox antibody test ✅ Extra ultrasound screening ❌ Triple-Test ❌ First trimester screening ❌ Neck fold measurement	✅ Chickenpox antibody test ✅ Fifth disease antibody test ✅ Strep antibody test ✅ Toxoplasmosis test ✅ chickenpox antibody test ✅ Extra ultrasound screening ❌ Triple-Test ❌ First trimester screening ❌ Neck fold measurement
Fertility treatment	First three attempts are legally insured. The insurer offers an additional subsidy of up to 200€ for the first three attempts.	✅ First three attempts are legally insured. The insurer offers an additional subsidy of up to 500€ for the first three attempts.
Midwife on call service Midwife on call means that you have a midwife available around the clock to support you while giving birth. Not all midwives offer this service.	Up to 300€ per annum (max 80%)	Up to 250€ per annum
💪 Sport	💛 💛 🤍	💛 💛 🤍
Sport medical examination Medical examination to check physical fitness. The examination is recommended for both beginners and experienced athletes.	✅ Up to 140€ per annum every 24 months.	Up to 120€ per annum (max 80 %) every 24 months.

Health courses You can reimburse part of the health courses cost in the areas of exercise, nutrition, relaxation, stress management and addiction. The course must be listed in the "Central Testing Center for Prevention."	Up to 200€ per annum (max 80 %)	Up to 150€ per annum (max 80 %)
🧘‍♀️ **Osteopathy**	💛 💛 💛	💛 💛 💛
Treatment Osteopathy is a form of alternative medicine that believes the body has an inherent ability to heal itself. It uses techniques like stretching, massaging, and manipulating muscles and joints to treat back pain, joint problems, and sports injuries.	✅ Up to 160€ per annum	Up to 120€ per annum
Homeopathy	💛 💛 💛	💛 💛 💛
Medicine	Up to 100€ per annum	Up to 100€ per annum

Source: Public health insurance website

Are there significant differences in public health insurance companies in Germany?

No, you won't find significant differences in the services offered by different public health insurers in Germany. The reason is that the German government regulates the services every public health insurance company must provide.

So, one can loosely say that 95% of the services are the same among all the public health insurance providers in Germany. The difference is in the services like alternative medicines, bonus programs, dental subsidies, etc. This difference is also not that big.

Cheapest public health insurance companies in Germany

The top five cheapest public health insurance companies in Germany are.

Health insurance contribution	10.22% for students below 30 14.6% for students 30 or above/employees/self-employed	
Public health insurance company	**Additional contribution (Zusatzbeitrag) 2024**	**Total Health insurance contribution 2024**
BKK Firmus	= 0.9%	15,5% (14.6 + 0.9)
HKK	= 0,98%	15,58%
Audi BKK	⬇️ 1,0% (1.25% in 2023)	15,6%
Techniker Krankenkasse	= 1,2%	15,8%
HEK	= 1,3%	15,9%

Source: Public health insurance company's website

= Same, ⬆️ Increased, ⬇️ decreased as compared to the previous year

Why are some public health insurance providers more expensive than others?

There are two factors that affect the cost of public health insurance.

- How the public health insurance premium is calculated.

- How does the health insurer use income from premiums to pay the medical expenses?

How is the public health insurance premium calculated?

Statutory health insurance premiums depend on your gross monthly income. It's 14.6% of your gross income plus an additional contribution (Zusatzbeitrag in German).

Each public health insurance company sets its own additional contribution percentage. As of 2024, the average additional contribution is 1.7% of your gross monthly income.

So, the total public health insurance premium is 16.3% (14.6 + 1.7%) of your gross monthly salary as of 2024.

As you can see, the premium depends on your salary. The more you earn, the more you pay. So, it would be beneficial for the health insurance company to have more high-earner members.

On the other hand, if the insurer has more low-earning or retired individuals, the income from premiums declines drastically. Additionally, more elderly members mean more medical expenses for the health insurer.

The ratio of young paying members to old retired members is crucial when determining the premium. The public health insurance provider can reduce the premium if it has a higher percentage of young earners as members than old members.

How does the health insurer use income from premiums to pay the medical expenses?

Public health insurance companies work in a backward system. This means they pay the medical expenses first and rely on their paying members to fund them.

Moreover, everyone pays into the common health insurance fund. The insurance company uses the amount in this reserve to fund the medical expenses of all its members.

If the income from the premiums is not enough to cover the medical expenses. Health insurer has no choice but to increase the premiums.

Again, the ratio of young paying members to old retired members plays a significant role here.

How do you switch public health insurance in Germany?

Changing public health insurance providers is straightforward. Moreover, you get support from your future health insurance provider.

Changing your public health insurance provider is a 4 step process.

1. Find a new health insurance provider

There are 96 public health insurance companies in Germany. You can choose from any one of them.

We find TK the best public health insurance provider for expats. It offers its website, mobile app, and customer support in English.

2. Register with the new health insurance company

Most public health insurers offer online registration. The registration form asks for some standard personal and professional information. It takes only 2 minutes to complete and submit the registration form.

You can register with TK online here.

3. Cancelling your old public health insurance

Your new health insurer will take care of canceling your contract with the old insurer. So, you don't have to do anything here. This also ensures uninterrupted coverage.

The old health insurance company will confirm your cancellation within 14 days. The new health insurance company will also inform you if the change was successful.

4. Inform your employer

You must also inform your employer about the change. Assuming you are employed and subject to social insurance contributions.

An email to your HR about the change is usually enough. Your employer can then ask for more information if required.

What should you keep in mind when changing public health insurance companies?

You must take care of the two things when making the switch.

- **Notice period:** Usually 2 months to the end of the month
- **Commitment period:** Usually one year

Notice period

When changing public insurance providers, you must serve a notice period, which is usually two full months to the end of the month.

For example, suppose you decided to change health insurance companies on March 5, 2025. At the earliest, you can become a member of the new public health insurance company by June 1, 2025.

Commitment period

You have a one-year commitment period after switching your public health insurance company. This means you can only change your new statutory health insurance provider after one year has passed.

What is the special right to terminate your public health insurance?

Special right of termination means you can cancel your contract without serving the commitment period.

You have a special right of termination if your health insurance company increases the monthly premiums. In this case, the commitment period doesn't apply. However, you must still serve the notice period.

You have until the end of the month from which the new premium applies to terminate your contract.

For example, suppose your health insurance company will increase the monthly premiums from 1st Feb. In this case, you have until the end of February to cancel your contract using your special right of termination.

> **NOTE**: You have a special right to termination only if the "additional contribution (Zuzsatzbeitrag)" increases. Don't confuse it with an increase in insurance premiums in general.

Even if the additional contribution stays stable, public health insurance premiums still increase on average by 3.3% each year.

Best private health insurance companies

Things you should know about the ratings

- These ratings are based on the snapshot of a specific sample customer. So, you should not completely rely on these ratings. Every individual and their needs are different. Thus, you should get personalized advice from a fee-based insurance advisor or an insurance broker.
- The rating agencies rate private health insurance policies based on different criteria and weights. Some criteria that are relevant for you might not be considered in these tests.

You are now aware of the shortcomings of the rating results. Let's check which health insurance policies and companies came out on top.

Best private health insurance in Germany (Summary)

We extracted the private health insurance companies and plans that were rated the best by multiple rating agencies here. You can find which agency rated it and how later in this guide.

Best private health insurance companies

Map-Report, DFSI, and IVFP compared and rated private health insurance companies based on different factors. All three of them rated **Signal Iduna** the best.

LVM was rated excellent by Map-Report and IVFP.

Best private health insurance tariffs

Here are the private health insurance plans that were rated the best by Handelblatt, Focus Money, and Morgen and Morgen.

Basic protection	Standard protection	Top protection
Hallesche “NK.select S Bonus, NK.select Flex URZ”	Gothaer „MediCompactPlus“	Hallesche “NK.select XL Bonus, URZ”
AXA “EL Bonus-U, Komfort Zahn-U, KUR-U/100”	AXA “ActiveMe-U, Komfort Zahn-U, KUR-U/100”	Arag “MedBest”
HanseMerkur „KVS1,EKV2, KUT/100“	Hallesche “NK.select L Bonus, URZ”	DKV “BMK0, BMZ1, BMKD”
Debeka „NW“	R+V „Agil comfort U“	HanseMerkur “AZP, EGO, PS3, PSV”
		Continentale „Premium, SP1“

> **NOTE**: Hallesche “NK.select XL Bonus, URZ” is also rated the top private health insurance plan by M&M. You can get Hallesche insurance policy from Feather*. Feather is an insurance agent and offer services in English.

Conclusion

Hallesche and Signal Iduna received above-average ratings from all the rating agencies in Germany.

We recommend getting private health insurance via an insurance broker. They are experts and can help you find the best plan for your needs. You can book a call with an expert we recommend here.

Insurance brokers and advisors are liable for their advice. This means that if the insurance plan they recommended doesn’t fulfill your wishes, they are liable to pay the damages.

Insurance brokers offer free advice. The insurance company pays them upon the successful conclusion of the contract.

An insurance broker can also help you file a claim with the provider. The broker we recommend has been offering services to expats for more than a decade.

Best private health insurance plans per Handelsblatt 2023

Who rated the private health insurance plans?

Handelsblatt, together with Franke and Bornberg (Map-Report), analyzed private health insurance policies.

You can read the full review here (German).

How were the private health insurance plans rated?

- The private health insurance tariffs were divided into three categories
    - **Basic protection:** Tariffs that offer coverage similar to public health insurance.
    - **Standard protection:** In addition to basic protection, the tariff covers psychotherapy, an electric wheelchair, a twin room, and 60% dentures.
    - **Top protection:** The tariff reimburses the costs of alternative practitioners, single rooms, treatment by the head doctor, implants, and at least 80% of the denture costs. In addition, doctors' services are billed and reimbursed up to the maximum GOZ and GÖA rate.
- Handelsblatt rated private health insurance policies for each category separately.
- They gave 70% weightage to the health insurance performance and 30% to the insurance cost.
- The sample customer was a 35-year-old individual.

> **NOTE:** The rating is for a particular private health insurance policy and not the company.

Result

Basic protection	Standard protection	Top protection
Hallesche “NK.select S Bonus, NK.select Flex URZ”	R+V „Agil comfort U“	Hallesche “NK.select XL Bonus, URZ”
AXA “EL Bonus-U, Komfort Zahn-U, KUR-U/100”	Gothaer „MediCompact Plus“	Gothaer „MediCompact Premium“
HanseMerkur „KVS1,EKV2, KUT/100“	AXA “ActiveMe-U, Kompakt Zahn-U, KUR-U/100”	Continentale „Premium, SP1“
Debeka „NW“	Hallesche “NK.select L Bonus, URZ”	Arag “MedBest”
R+V „Agil classic pro U“	Continentale „Premium, SP2“	Deutscher Ring „Comfort+, PIT”
uniVersa „uni-intro Privat 300, uni-ZZ“	Arag „K600, FlexiPro“	UKV – Union/BBKK „GesundheitsVario, AmbulantPlus, KlinikPlus, ZahnPlus
	Württembergische „Ambulant Komfort Hausarzt (A2H), Stationär Komfort (S2), Zahn Kompakt (Z3)“	HanseMerkur „AZP, EGO, PS3“
	Süddeutsche „AM30, S1, Z6“	uniVersa „uni-A80, uni-ST Stufe 1/100, uni-ZA 100, uni-KU/100“
	Debeka „N“	Signal Iduna „Exklusiv-Plus1, KurPlus/100“
		DKV „BMK0, BMZ1,, BMKD“
		Süddeutsche „AM12, S1, Z9“

Best private health insurance plans per Focus Money 2023

Who rated the private health insurance plans?

Focus-Money, together with the rating agency Franke and Bornberg (Map-Report), rated private health insurance plans in Germany.

You can read the complete analysis in Focus-Money magazine (issues 40, 41, and 42).

How were the private health insurance plans rated?

- The private health insurance tariffs were divided into three categories
    - **Basic protection**: Tariffs that offer coverage similar to public health insurance.
    - **Standard protection:** In addition to basic protection, the tariff covers psychotherapy, an electric wheelchair, a twin room, and 60% dentures.
    - **Top protection:** The tariff reimburses the costs of alternative practitioners, single rooms, treatment by the head doctor, implants, and at least 80% of the denture costs. In addition, doctors' services are billed and reimbursed up to the maximum GOZ and GÖA rate.
- Like Handelsblatt, Focus-money rated private health insurance policies for each category separately.
- They gave 50% weightage to the scope of services, 30% to the insurance cost, and 20% to the financial strength.
- The sample customer was a 35-year-old individual.

Result

Basic protection	Standard protection	Top protection
Hallesche “NK.select S Bonus, NK.select Flex URZ”	Gothaer „MediCompactPlus“	Hallesche “NK.select XL Bonus, URZ”
AXA “EL Bonus-U, Komfort Zahn-U, KUR-U/100”	AXA “ActiveMe-U, Komfort Zahn-U, KUR-U/100”	Debeka „N, NC“
HanseMerkur „KVS1,EKV2, KUT/100“	Hallesche “NK.select L Bonus, URZ”	Arag “MedBest”
Debeka „NW“	R+V „Agil comfort U“	DKV “BMK0, BMZ1, BMKD”
		HanseMerkur “AZP, EGO, PS3, PSV”
		Continentale „Premium, SP1“

Best private health insurance plans per Morgen & Morgen 2024

Who rated the private health insurance plans?

Morgen & Morgen (M&M) compared and rated private health insurance plans. You can read the full review here (German).

How were the private health insurance plans rated?

- M&M rated the private health insurance based on 60 questions.
- They gave weightage to all the questions based on their importance.
- M&M assigned a score to each question based on whether the health insurance plan
    - fully fulfills it (100% of score),

    - partially fulfills it (50% of score), or
    - doesn't fulfill it (0).
- Besides the score, private health insurance plans must meet certain minimum criteria to get the top rating.
- M&M considered three professional groups
    - Normal professional group: Everyone who is qualified to get private health insurance
    - Civil servants
    - Doctors

Result

Here, we share only the private health insurance policies that received the highest rating. You can check the M&M website for tariffs with lower ratings.

> **NOTE:** The tariffs are alphabatically ordered in the table. They all are rated five stars by M&M.

Normal professional group	Civil servants	Doctors
Allianz (GSB70, GSUB90, GSUB100, GSZ100, PVN)	Allianz (Outpatient allowance 51, hospital allowance 51, dental allowance 51, hospital single room, PVB, daily hospital allowance)	Allianz (Doctors Best 100 [G])
AXA (ActiveMe-U, Komfort Zahn-U, KUR-U/50)	Barmenia (GK30, GK20P, G1B, G2B30, G2B20P, GEPlus, PVB, KH+)	AXA (VA6-U, Prem Zahn-U, KUR-U/50, VIAlife)
Barmenia (EXP1+)	SPCA (Vision B 50T-U, BW2 50T-U, BWE-U, BN3/1 50-U, KUR-U/50)	Barmenia (VHV1A+)

BBKK (GesundheitVARIO 400, VARIO KlinikPlus, VARIO ZahnPlus, VARIO AmbulantPlus, Courtagegeld)	Hallesche (CAZ.30, CAZ.120, CG.230, CG.320, CSD., CSR.30, CSR.120, BEb.50, JOKER.flex)	Hallesche (MAS.Bonus)
Gothaer (MediCompact Premium 240)	Ottonova (B22AZ30, B22AZ20K, B21BC30, B21BC20K, B21S30, B21S20K, B21FC100, PVB, KHT)	Inter (JABest)
Hallesche (NK.select XL Bonus, JOKER.flex)	R+V (BB30, BB20E, W130, W120E, EB1)	SDK (AM10 (Ärzte), S1 (Ärzte), Z9)
Inter (QMP 300 U)		
Ottonova (First Class Pro+)		
R+V (Agile premium TN0U)		
SDK (AM1x, S1, Z9)		
Signal Iduna (Prime)		
UKV (HealthVARIO 400, VARIO KlinikPlus, VARIO ZahnPlus, VARIO AmbulantPlus)		
Universe (uni-Top|Privat 300)		
Württemberg (Outpatient Premium 480 SB, inpatient Premium, dental Premium)		

Best private health insurance companies per Map-Report 2023

So far, the rating agencies have analyzed and rated particular private health insurance plans.

However, Map-Report rated the private health insurance companies instead.

Map-Report requested several private health insurance companies participate in the analysis. However, not every company agreed to participate.

Thus, many private insurance companies might not be part of this list. It's not because they didn't perform but because they didn't participate in the review.

Map-Report examined the insurance companies in three areas:

- Service
- Contract data
- Balance sheet

The **top five private health insurance companies** based on Map-Report's analysis are

- Debeka
- Signal Iduna
- LVM
- VGH Provincial
- Alte Oldenburgers

Best private health insurance companies per IVFP 2023

IVFP (Institut Für Vorsorge unde Finanzplanung) examined private health insurance companies and rated them based on four factors

- Company's stability
- Security

- Market success (Customer satisfaction)
- Profitability

IVFP updates the private health insurance company's rating results annually. It gives companies one of the following grades.

- Excellent
- Very Good
- Good
- Satisfactory
- Sufficient
- Poor
- Unsatisfactory

The table below lists the companies that received the grades "Excellent" and "Very Good." The table is sorted alphabetically.

Company	**Grade**
LVM	Excellent
Provinzial Krankenversicherung Hannover AG	Excellent
R+V	Excellent
SIGNAL IDUNA	Excellent
uniVersa	Excellent
Allianz Private	Very Good
ALTE OLDENBURGER	Very Good
AXA	Very Good

Barmenia	Very Good
Bayerische Beamtenkrankenkasse AG (BBKK)	Very Good
Continentale	Very Good
Debeka	Very Good
DEVK	Very Good
DKV	Very Good
Generali Deutschland	Very Good
Gothaer	Very Good
HALLESCHE	Very Good
HanseMerkur	Very Good
INTER	Very Good
Landeskrankenhilfe V.V.a.G. (LKH)	Very Good
Mecklenburgische	Very Good
Union	Very Good
Württembergische	Very Good

The results were published on 5 Dec. 2023 (Source: [5])

Best private health insurance companies per DFSI 2023

DFSI used the following data to examine the private health insurance companies.

- The 2022 annual financial statements of private health insurers.
- Complaint statistics, according to BaFin
- DFSI product ratings from 2023

DFSI rated the insurance companies based on three factors.

- Substance strength: It indicates how likely an insurer is to offer stable or moderately increasing premiums in the future. It also examines whether the insurer can survive financial crises without major fluctuations.
- Product quality and variety
- Service: DFSI analyzed Bafin's customer complaint statistics and the insurer's health services. They gave 70% weightage to health services and 30% to complaint statistics.

DFSI gave the following weightage to the three factors.

- 40% to substance strength
- 40% to product quality
- 20% to services

You can read the complete report here (German).

These are top private health insurance companies per DFSI analysis.

Insurer	Overall Rating	Substance Strength	Product Quality	Service
Allianz	Excellent (1.0)	Very good (1.3)	Excellent (1.0)	Excellent (0.5)
SIGNAL IDUNA	Very good (1.1)	Excellent (1.0)	Very good (1.1)	Very good (1.4)
Barmenia	Very good (1.1)	Very good (1.4)	Excellent (0.9)	Excellent (0.9)
HanseMerkur	Very good (1.2)	Very good (1.3)	Very good (1.3)	Excellent (0.8)
HALLESCHE	Very good (1.2)	Very good (1.5)	Excellent (1.0)	Very good (1.3)
ARAG	Very good (1.3)	Very good (1.4)	Excellent (1.0)	Gut (1,7)

Württembergische	Very good (1.3)	Very good (1.5)	Very good (1.4)	Excellent (0.8)
R+V	Very good (1.5)	Very good (1.3)	Excellent (1.0)	Satisfactory (2.9)
INTER	Very good (1.5)	Very good (1.1)	Very good (1.5)	Gut (2,2)

The results are published on 24 Oct 2023 (Source: [6])

Future outlook

Only relevant if you are planning to settle in Germany after your studies.

Break up of private health insurance premium

Private health insurance premium consists of the following components

Up to 60

- **Risk portion (Riskioanteil / Risikozuschlag):** Your premium's "Risk portion" is based on the statistical medical costs of people in your age group. It's different for each insurance provider.
- **Cost portion (Kostenanteil):** This covers the insurance company's administrative costs, such as taking out insurance, settling claims, etc.
- **Savings portion (Sparanteil):** The insurance company saves part of your premium to compensate for the increased medical costs as you age. Every insurance provider saves a different percentage of your premium. The more an insurer saves, the better. Insurers like Hallesche, Universa, R+V, etc., have stable premiums for a long time because they save a higher percentage of your premium.
- **10% statutory surcharge (Gesetzlicher Zuschlag):** The 10% statutory surcharge is required by law. Every private insurer must charge this to its customers. The amount is saved and invested. It's used to keep the premium stable in old age. The surcharge complements the saving portion (Sparanteil) made by the private insurer.

The savings portion (Sparanteil) plus the statutory surcharge (Gesetzlicher Zuschlag) together are called **aging provisions** (Alterungsrückstellung in German).

Additionally, you also pay for

- **Long-term nursing care insurance:** It's mandatory by law. You pay the same amount as in the statutory long-term nursing care insurance.
- **Sickness benefits insurance:** It's optional but highly recommended. It pays sick pay after the 43rd day of your long-term sickness.

- **Risk surcharge:** Lastly, the private health insurance company charges a risk surcharge based on your existing illnesses. You don't pay any risk surcharge if you don't have any existing diseases.

From 60 to 67 (until you retire)

- You stop paying a 10% statutory surcharge.

After retirement

- You stop paying for sickness benefits insurance.
- You stop paying a 10% statutory surcharge.

> **NOTE**: When you switch your private health insurance provider, you can transfer part of your old age provisions to the new provider. The amount of old age provisions you can transfer to the new provider is called "transfer value (Übertragungswert)."

Every insurance company calculates the **transfer value (Übertragungswert)** differently. However, it's around 70% of your total aging reserve.

So, you lose 30% of your savings if you change the private health insurance company. This is why you should get expert's help when taking private health insurance in Germany.

How do private health insurers calculate the monthly premium?

The private health insurance provider calculates your contribution based on

- the scope of services,
- your age,
- any pre-existing illnesses,

- life expectancy (statistically calculated), and
- medical expenses you may incur throughout the insured period (statistically calculated).

Additionally, private health insurance companies segregate people into groups based on their tariffs and age when taking the insurance.

Private insurers create a pool of funds for each group. It saves part of the contributions of the insured in this fund.

The funds saved by the group over time cover

- the medical costs of sick people in the group and
- compensate for the increased medical expenses in the future.

Private insurance providers aim that the total premium collected over the entire insurance period is enough to cover all expected insurance benefits throughout the insured person's life.

So, in younger years, larger parts of your monthly contribution are saved and invested. These savings are called retirement provisions or aging provisions.

Private insurance companies use the aging provisions to

- cover higher medical expenses in the future
- and keep the premiums stable as you grow old.

Unlike public health insurance, which relies on young professionals to pay the increased medical expenses, private insurance builds up a savings cushion.

Difference between public and private health insurance premium calculations

Private health insurance	Public health insurance
Premium has increased on average 3.2% in the last 10 years (2004 to 2024)	Premium has increased on average 3.3% in the last 10 years (2004 to 2024)
Private insurance is usually cheaper for high earners throughout their life.	Public insurance is usually expensive for high earners throughout their life.
Premium depends on age, existing illnesses, and tariff	Premium depends on your gross income
Creates an aging provision to cover the increased medical expenses in the future	No aging provision
It calculates the premium for each individual to cover the medical services benefits from the start of insurance to the insured person's death.	Public insurance is always hand-to-mouth. It pays for the bills now and relies on young professionals to cover the costs.
Private insurers cannot change the contractually agreed services.	Public insurance is reducing medical services almost every year.
A 35-year-old with a top private health insurance plan pays around 650 € per month (as of 2024).	A 35-year-old with public health insurance pays around 1050 € per month
Based on the current trend of increasing medical expenses and insurance premiums, the 35-year-old individual from above will pay around 1670 € per month after 30 years (65 years old or in 2054).	Based on the current trend of increasing medical expenses and insurance premiums, the 35-year-old individual from above will pay around 2780 € per month after 30 years (65 years old).
Based on the current trend and subsidies, you'll pay around 1370 € per month after retirement (67 years old or in 2056)	People insured under public health insurance for retirees (KVdR) pay a monthly subsidized premium of 1170 € per month after retirement (67 years old or in 2056).

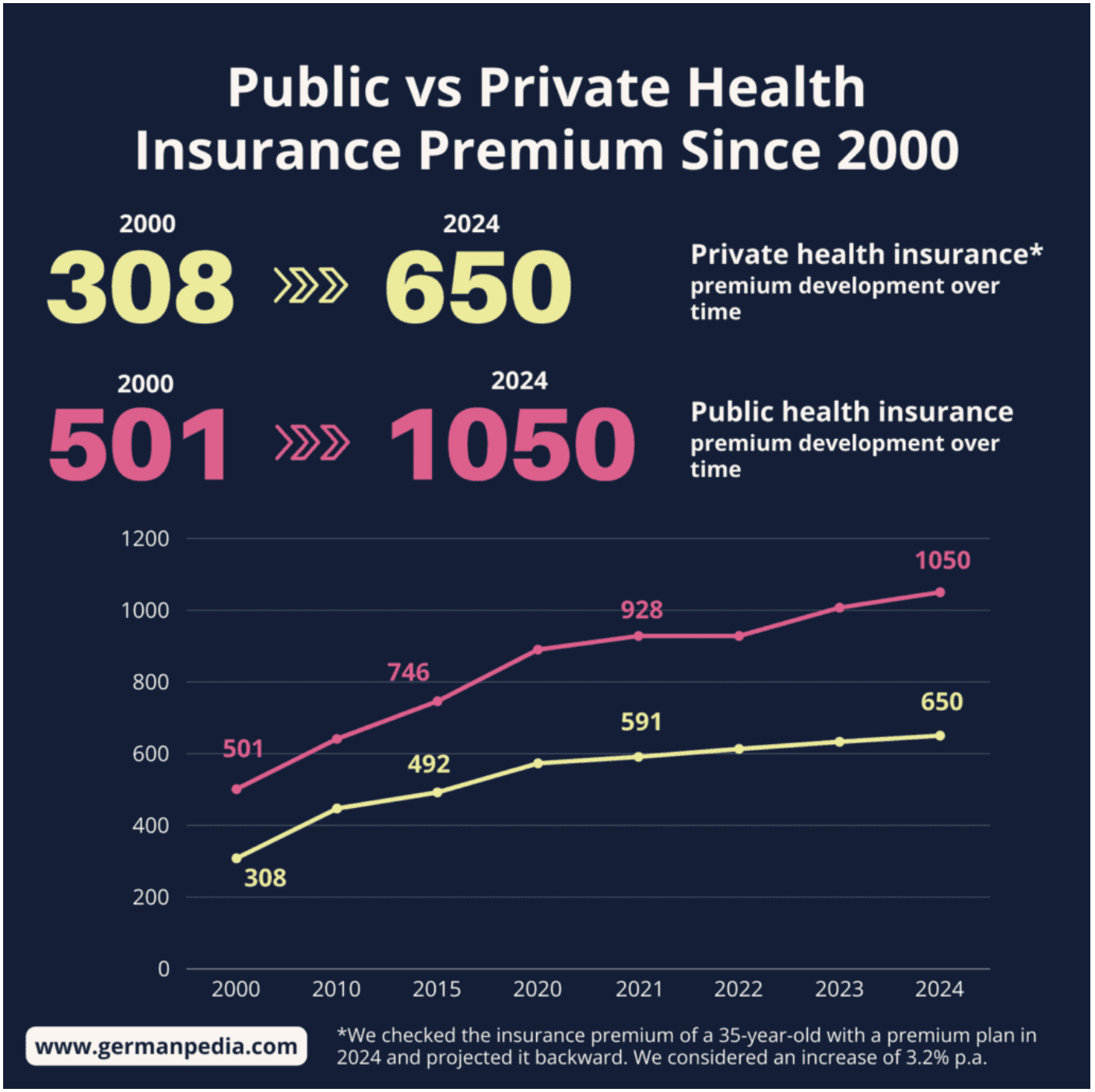
Conclusion

Private health insurance is cheaper for high earners. Moreover, it's better prepared for the rise of medical expenses in the future and Germany's growing older population.

So, if you are a high earner and believe you'll continue to earn high in the future, you should consider moving to private health insurance.

Besides that, everyone should save a cushion to cover their medical expenses in old age.

Private health insurance is a complicated product. So, we recommend consulting a fee-based advisor or an insurance broker for personalized advice.



As the image above shows, private health insurance has been cheaper than public health insurance since 2000.

How much did the private health insurance premium rise in the past?

It's one thing for your health insurance premium to rise 2% to 3% yearly. But if it grows abruptly more than 10% or 20%, it can affect your finances greatly.

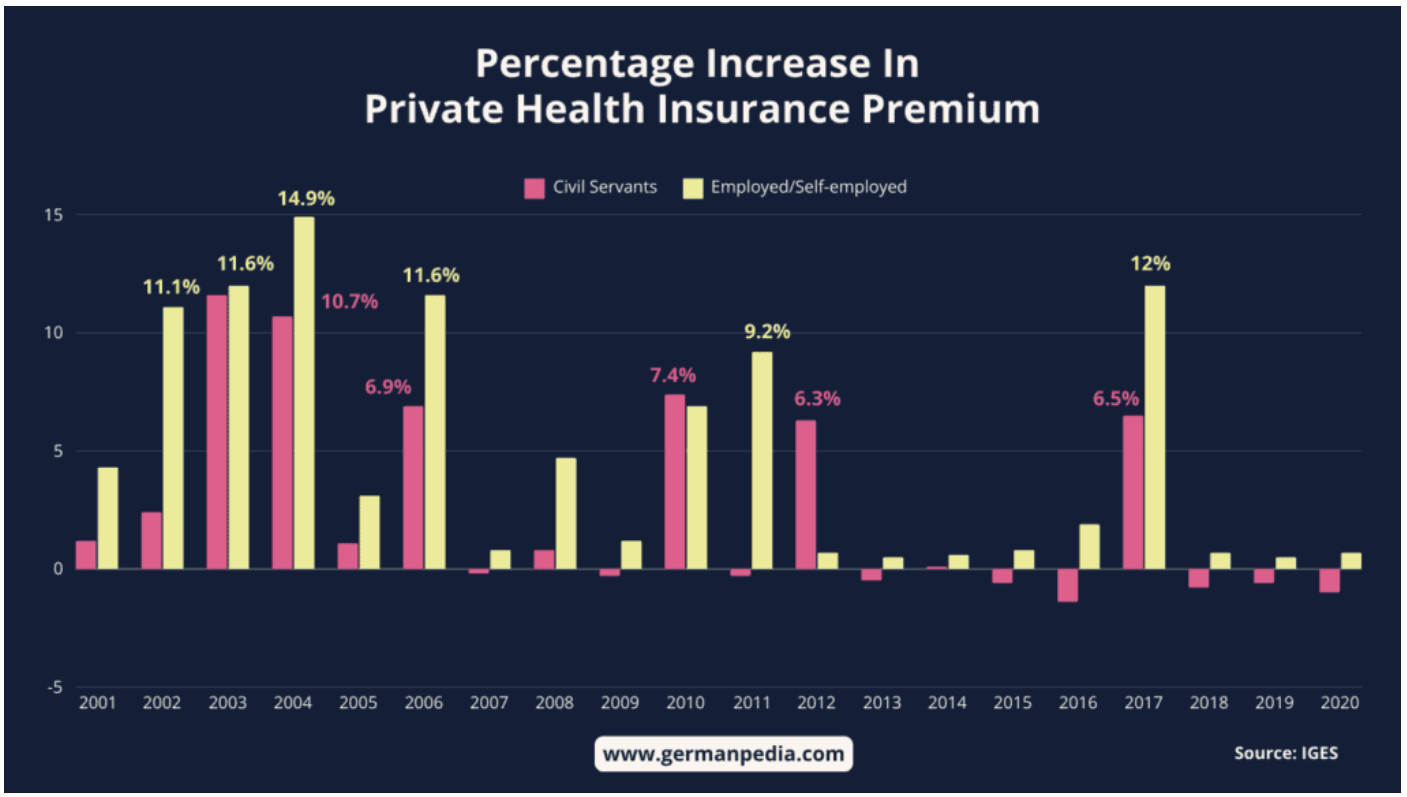
Unfortunately, private health insurance premiums can rise more than 10% in one year.

Abrupt rise of private health insurance premium

IGES studied the premium development of Debeka's 800,000 private health insurance members between 2000 and 2020. In the study, researchers found that private health premiums rose abruptly

- at least twice 20% or more, or
- at least five times 10% or more

The researchers found that this sudden jump in the insurance premium affected 39% of the employed and self-employed. The percentage reduces to 13% for civil servants.



Source: IGES

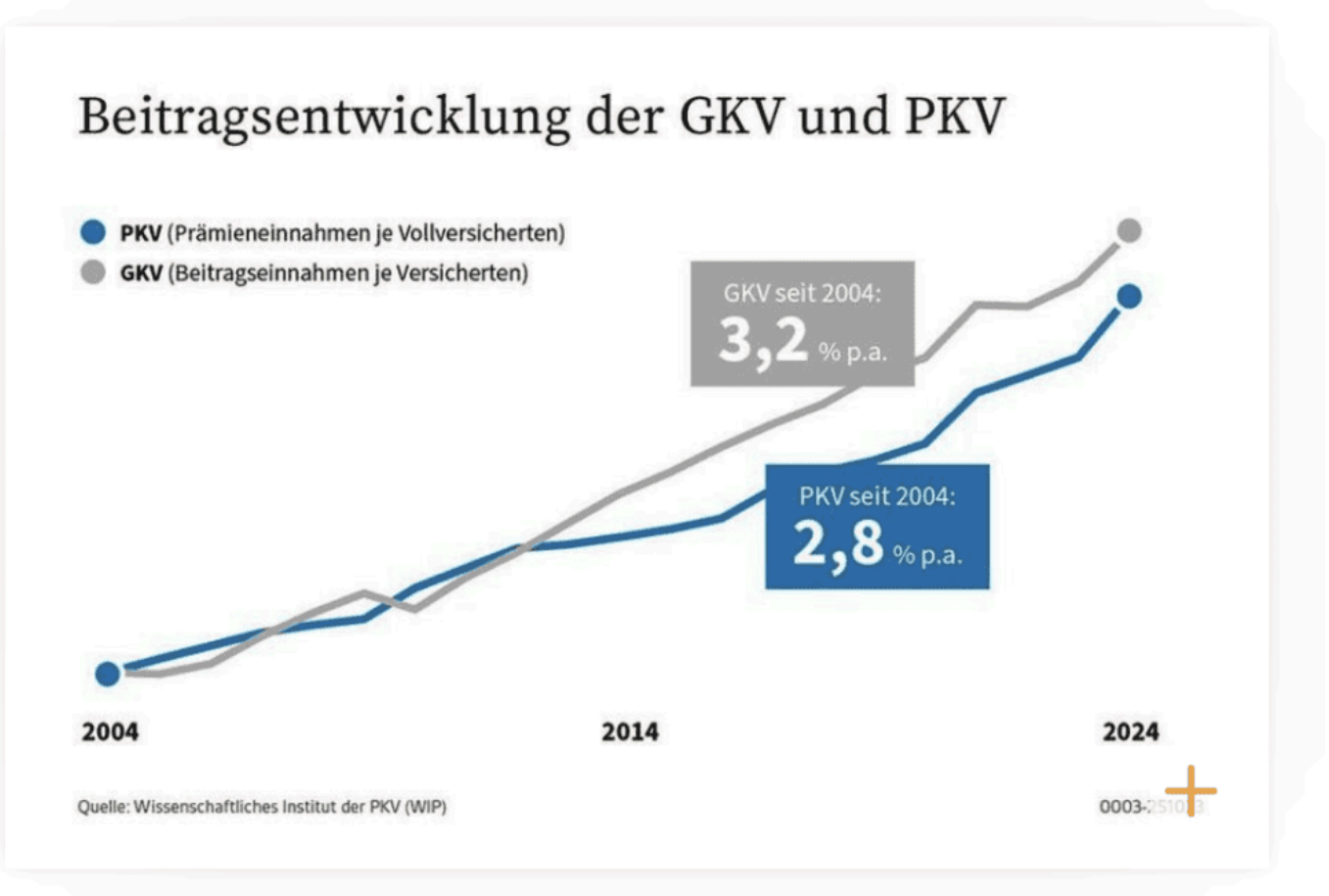
Debeka is the largest private health insurance company in terms of the number of privately insured members (2.5 million customers as of 2024). This is a quarter of the total privately insured people in Germany.

So, even if Debeka doesn't represent the whole private health insurance industry, we can still get a good picture of the premium development.

Average increase in private and public health insurance premiums over 20 years

Although private health insurance costs increase by a large percentage abruptly, the average increase in premiums over 20 years is 2.8% (2004 to 2024).

Conversely, public health insurance costs have increased by 3.2% per annum over the past twenty years (2004 to 2024).

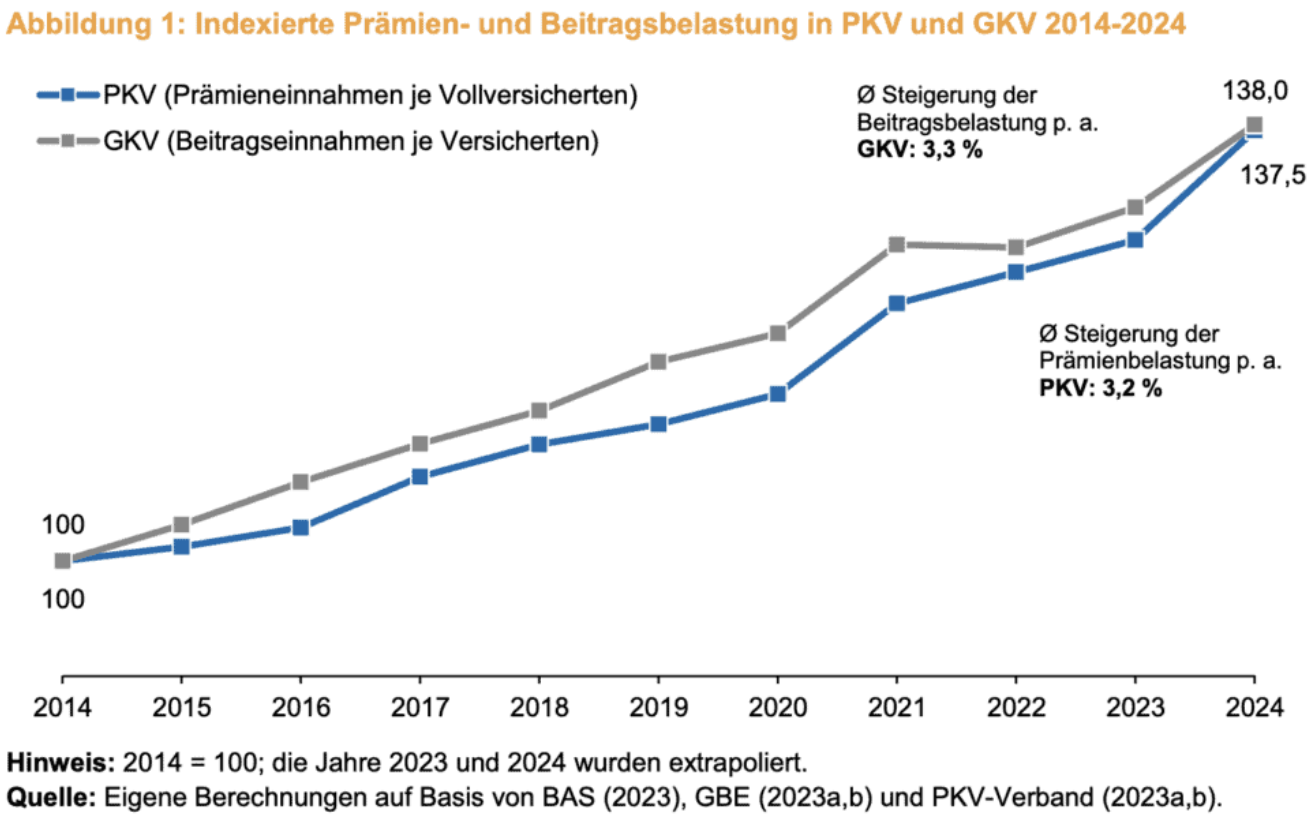


Source: WIP [2]

Average private and statutory health insurance premium increase in over 10 years

Health insurance costs in Germany have increased faster in the last ten years (2014 to 2024) than in the last twenty years.

- Private health insurance costs increased by 3.2% per annum.
- Public health insurance costs increase by 3.3% per annum.



Source: WIP [2]

Why do private health insurance costs rise abruptly in Germany?

Private health insurance companies can only make a premium adjustment if the cost of insurance benefits in the tariff has increased by at least 10%.

This restriction on increasing insurance premiums is intended to protect consumers. However, it has a side effect, i.e., the abrupt increase in private health insurance premiums.

It's because medical treatment costs are increasing continuously due to inflation and medical progress. However, the insurer cannot increase the premiums continuously.

Let's understand it with an example.

Suppose the cost of insurance benefits in your tariff increases by 4% every year. So, it'll take three years to cross the threshold of 10%.

You'll continue to pay the same premium during these three years. However, the insurance company must cover the increased medical costs.

Thus, when the time comes to increase insurance premiums, the insurer compensates for the increased costs in the past years in one fell swoop. This leads to an abrupt rise in private health insurance premiums.

Reasons for the increase in private health insurance costs in Germany

- **Low interest rate:** Private health insurance companies must save part of the premium (retirement provision). The insurer invests this saved amount to earn interest. The insurer uses the saved amount plus the earned interest to keep the insurance cost stable in old age. However, due to the low interest rate in the past decade, insurers cannot earn good interest. Thus, they must charge higher premiums to compensate for the low interest.
- **Inflation:** Medical costs increase each year due to inflation. Private health companies transfer this increased cost to their members by increasing the premium.
- **Medical science progress:** Innovations in the medical field offer better and more treatment options to patients. This leads to increased medical spending and a cost burden on health insurance companies. Ultimately, the increased costs are passed on to the end customers.
- **Longer life expectancy:** Life expectancy in Germany is around 81 years [1]. Statistically, each year costs the health system about twice as much as the previous one.

All the above factors are contributing to Germany's increased medical expenditures. Medical expenditures are rising consistently and were 497.7 billion euros in 2022. German health insurance needs money to cover these medical expenditures. However, current monthly health insurance contributions are not enough.

As a result, the German government has to fund around 10% of the medical expenditure. [1] In short, an increase in the cost of health insurance is inevitable in the future.

Is private health insurance unaffordable in old age?

One of the most common fears that prevent people from purchasing private health insurance is that the premiums will be unaffordable in old age. However, that's not true.

The fear of unaffordable premiums emerged in the 1970s and 1980s. During this time, many young people bought private health insurance policies without or very low aging reserves.

No aging reserves made the insurance plans dirt cheap when young people bought them. However, insurance premiums rose drastically as people aged.

It's because there were no aging reserves to compensate for the rising medical costs. This made premiums unaffordable for many people from the baby boomer generation.

The baby boomer generation passed on their negative experiences to the next generation. This is why so many people fear joining the private health system.

However, the German government and private health insurance companies learned from the past. The government made it mandatory for private insurance providers to save 10% (since 2000) of the premium as an aging reserve.

The insurers must use the saved mandatory surcharge to stabilize the health insurance premium after retirement.

Additionally, almost every private health insurance company nowadays saves part of your premium as an aging reserve. The percentage of the premium saved varies from insurer to insurer.

However, good private health insurance companies save between 30% and 45% of your premium as an aging reserve.

The aging reserves compensate for the rising medical expenses and keep the premiums stable.

How much do you pay for private health insurance before and after retirement?

Private health insurance premiums have increased on average 3.2% in the last ten years (2014 to 2024). So, assuming the premiums will continue to rise at this rate, we have created the table below.

Other assumptions

- You took private health insurance at the age of 35.
- You don’t have any pre-existing illnesses.
- You took a premium private health insurance plan.

Yearly increase in private insurance premium	3.2%
Age (Nr. of years after taking private insurance)	**Private health insurance premium per month**
35	650 €
45 (10 years)	890 €
55 (20 years)	1220 €

65 (30 years)	1672 €

Private health insurance premium projection

Once you turn 60, you stop paying the 10% statutory surcharge.

After retirement

A few things change once you retire.

- You don’t pay for the daily sickness allowance.
- Your saved retirement provisions are used to compensate for the increased medical costs.
- You get a health insurance subsidy from statutory pension insurance. The maximum subsidy you can get is around 200 € per month as of 2024.
- If you were employed, you wouldn’t get your employer’s contributions anymore. Thus, you pay the whole premium yourself.

After considering the above subsidies and deductions, **your premium after retirement will be around 1370 € per month**.

Explanation

As you age, your medical expenses increase. However, your retirement provisions compensate for that increased medical cost. This way, you (65 years old) pay approximately the same premium as a 35-year-old individual would at that time.

For example, suppose you’ll retire in 2060. Assuming premiums rise at 3.2% per annum, the health insurance premium for a healthy 35-year-old individual will be around 1670 € in 2060.

As you are insured for 30 years and have created enough retirement provisions, you (65 years old) pay approximately the same premium (1670 €) as the 35-year-old individual.

After retirement, your premium decreases a bit as you get subsidies and don't pay 10% statutory surcharge and sickness benefit insurance.

How did we create this table?

We analyzed the actual health insurance premiums of people in different age groups. In our analysis, we found the following.

- A 70-year-old individual (insured for 35 years) pays approximately the same premium as a 35-year-old individual who just joined the insurer for the same services.
- After retirement, many people changed their tariffs to reduce the private health insurance premium.
- After retirement, many people increase their deductible considerably to reduce their premiums. However, they increase the deductible cleverly so that the effective premium (including the deductible) is still low.

You can check the actual private health insurance costs of 12 Universa's customers here.

Conclusion

Private health insurance premiums will continue to rise. You can expect to pay approximately 2.5 times more after retirement.

The same is true for the public health insurance premiums. Moreover, experts predict that public insurance costs will rise even more in the future. However, this applies only to high earners.

So, you should check if you can afford private health insurance in old age.

You have the following options if you cannot afford private health insurance in old age.

1. Every private health insurance provider is legally required to offer the “basic tariff.” The basic tariff offers the same services as public health insurance. Anyone who cannot afford private health insurance can go into the basic tariff.
2. Change your private health insurance plan after retirement to reduce the costs.
3. Increase your deductible to reduce the private health insurance costs.
4. Save a cushion when you are young and working. Use it to pay the insurance premiums when you are old and retired.

In short, if the worst happens, you’ll still have ways to get affordable health insurance.

Does private health insurance get more expensive than public over time?

Public health insurance premiums depend on your income. However, private health insurance premiums don’t.

Thus, if you earn less, you pay less for public health insurance.

So, to compare the costs of the two health systems meaningfully, we made the following assumptions.

- You are a high earner and pay maximum public health insurance premiums.
- You continue to earn high throughout your working life and even after retirement.

The answer is public health insurance costs more than private health insurance to high earners. Moreover, public health insurance costs have increased more than private health insurance over the past 20 years.

Here is a table that projects the cost of both health systems over time.

Age (Nr. of years after taking private insurance)	Private health insurance	Public health insurance
Yearly increase in premium over the past 10 years	3.2%	3.3%
Yearly increase in premium over the past 20 years	2.8%	3.2%
Premium of a high-earner, self-employed individual	**Premium increases by 3.2% per annum**	**Premium increases by 3.3% per annum**
35 (today)	650 € (as of 2024)	1051 € (as of 2024)
45 (after 10 years)	890 €	1454 €
55 (after 20 years)	1220 €	2011 €
65 (after 30 years)	1672 €	2780 €
After Retirement		
67	1570 € (you stop paying the sickness benefits)	1370 € (if you stay in public insurance throughout your work life)
Maximum subsidy from pension insurance	200 € (approx. as of 2024)	200 € (approx. as of 2024)
Net premium you pay after retirement (67)	1370 € (1570 – 200)	1170 € (1370 – 200)

Private and public health insurance cost projection (GermanPedia's calculations as of July 2024)

As you can see, if you are a high earner, you'll pay way more in the public system than in private throughout your work life. After retirement, the difference in the premiums is not big.

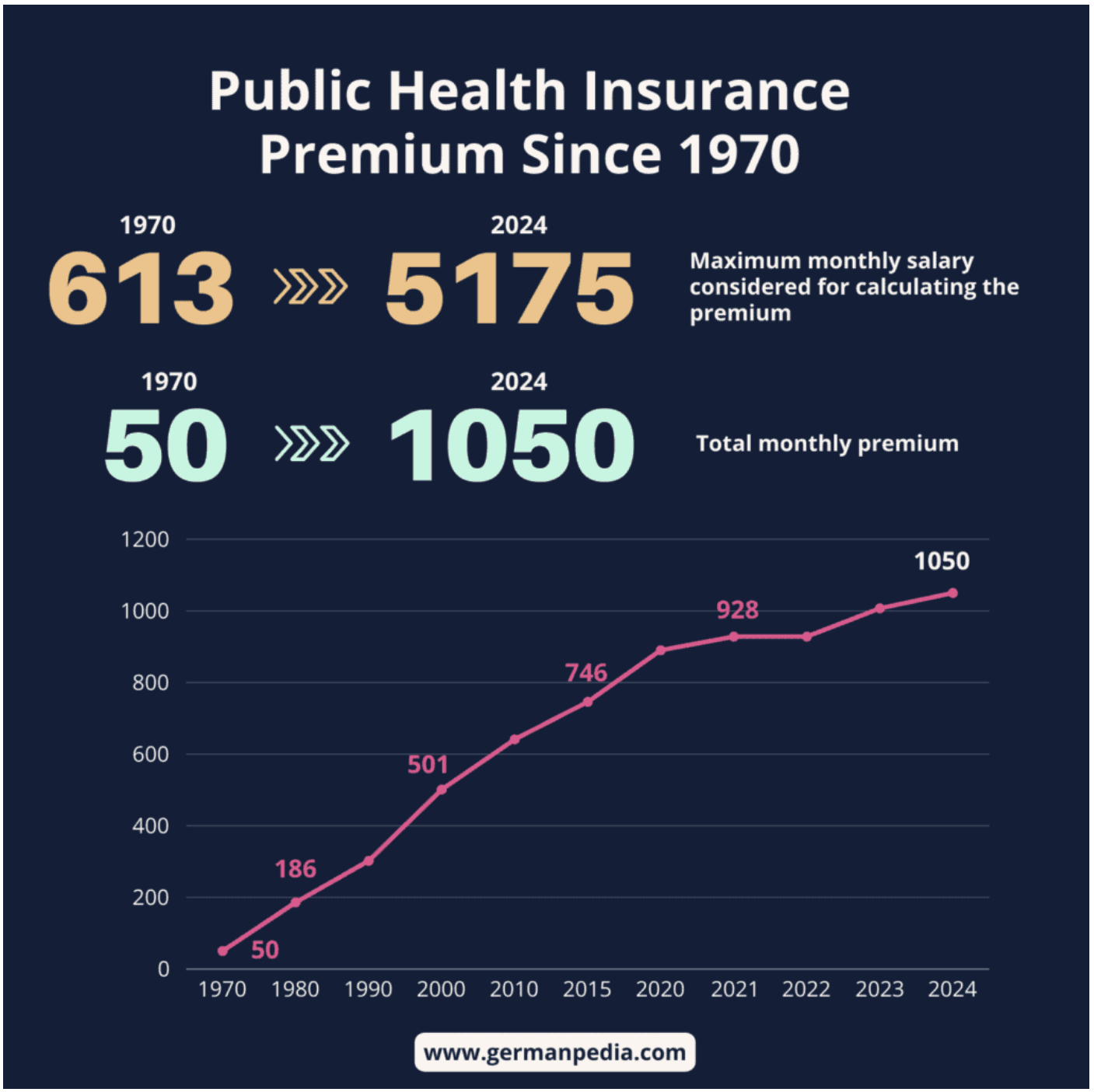
You can reduce the cost of private health insurance by changing your plan or increasing the deductible. However, you have no way of reducing your public insurance premium.

You should also consider that the public health system is in financial trouble. So, the chances that the German government will reduce or cut the health insurance subsidy for retirees in the future is high.

Lastly, paying more in the public system doesn't mean getting better services. On the contrary, good private health insurance plans offer better services than public insurance.

> **NOTE**: Private health insurance is for people who expect a high income throughout their career. If you are a low-earner or expect a reduced income in the future, public health insurance is better.

The image below shows the development of public health insurance premiums since 1970. As you can see, public insurance is 21 times more expensive in 2024 than in 1970.


Public Health Insurance Premium Since 1970
1970
613
2024
5175
Maximum monthly salary considered for calculating the premium
1970
50
2024
1050
Total monthly premium
1200
1000
800
600
400
200
0
1970
1980
1990
2000
2010
2015
2020
2021
2022
2023
2024
50
186
501
746
928
1050
www.germanpedia.com

How can private health insurance offer better services at a lower cost than public health insurance?

Private health insurance can offer better services at a lower cost than public health insurance for the following reasons.

- Private insurance accepts only healthy customers.
- Private insurance usually has people with better education and high income. Statistically, such people take care of their health more than others.
- Everyone pays for their health insurance. There is no free family insurance in the private system.
- Private health insurance saves part of the contributions (retirement provisions) to cover the increased medical costs in the future.

Future outlook of health insurance costs in Germany

As per health insurance and financial experts, the cost of both health systems will increase drastically. The public health system will be affected the most.

Future outlook of public health insurance costs in Germany

The public health insurance system works according to the backward distribution system. This means it first spends the money and relies on the young to pay the premiums.

However, by 2050, one-third of the German population will be 60 or older. Thus, Germany won't have enough earners to cover the medical expenditures of the public health system.

As there will be more old people in Germany by 2050, the cost burden on the public health system will increase.

On the other hand, the earning population will decrease. This will lead to a drastic increase in public health insurance costs.

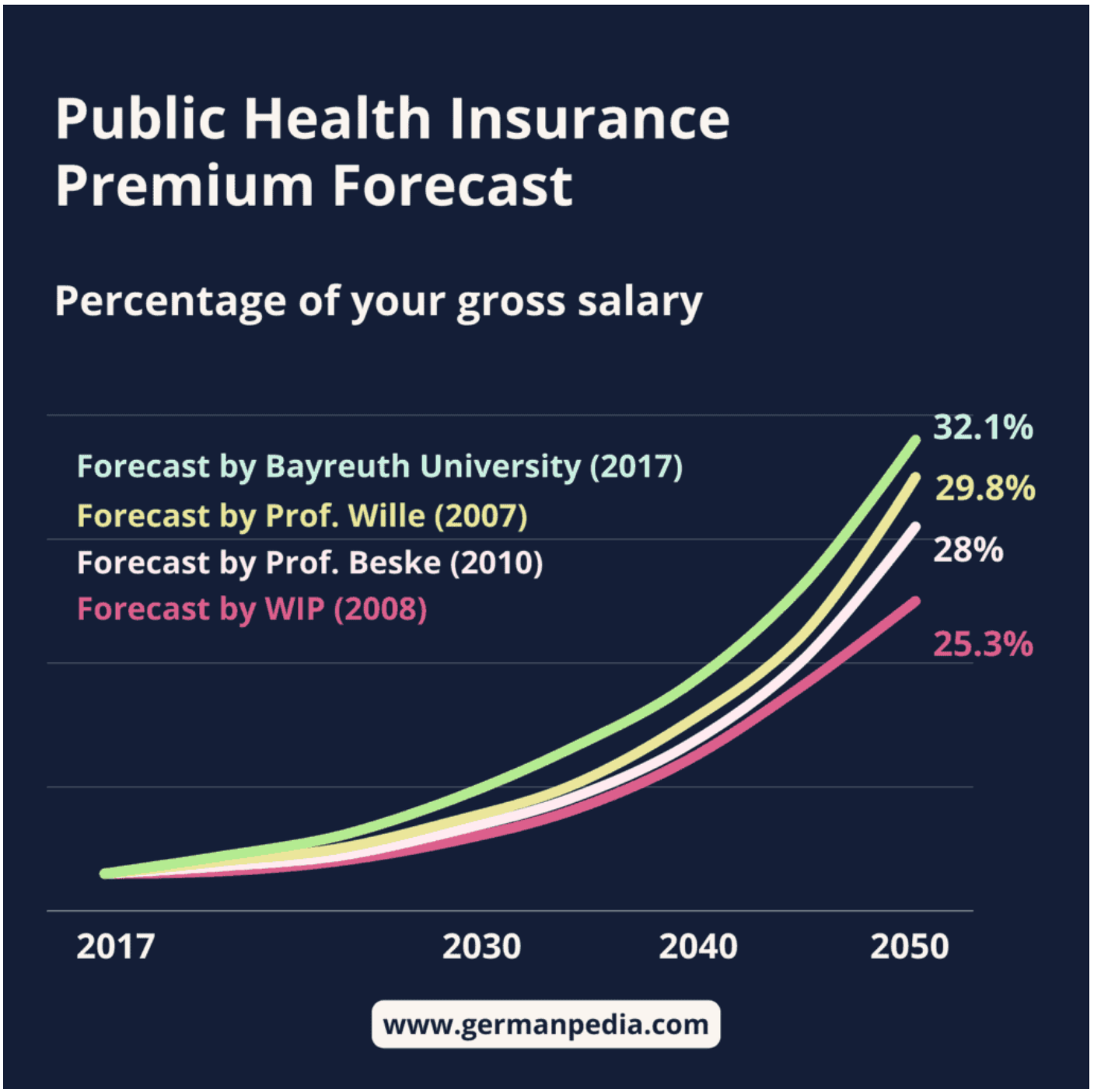
Additionally, public health insurance removes or limits medical coverage almost every year. The public health system is expected to further limit the medical services it covers in the future.

Experts' view on public health insurance costs in the future

Various experts predicted an increase in public health insurance costs by 2050. According to them, the public health insurance premium will be between 25% and 32% of your gross salary by 2050.

Currently, you contribute 16.3% (14.6% + 1.7% (additional contribution)) (as of 2024) of your gross salary in the public system.

The image below shows the experts' prediction of increasing public health insurance costs by 2050.



Future outlook of private health insurance costs in Germany

Both private and public health systems rely on each other. If one of them collapses, the other cannot survive alone.

So, you can expect a similar increase in private health insurance premiums. However, private health insurance doesn't work like public health insurance.

This is how the private health system works

Private health insurance companies create a group of individuals in the same age range. This group has its own pool of funds.

Everyone in the group pays for the medical coverage they contractually agreed. The private health insurance provider saves part of these contributions to the group's pool of funds.

The funds the group saved collectively over the years will cover the increased medical expenses. Hence, private insurance companies do not rely on someone else (young earners) to pay the increased medical expenses.

However, if the number of old and sick people in this group increases, the premium of individuals in this group will also increase.

You can check the live amount saved in Germany's private healthcare system here. When writing this guide, the total saved amount was 336 billion euros (July 2024).

Conclusion

The private health system is better prepared than the public system for the future.

- Private health insurance already has 336 billion euros saved to cover the increased medical expenses in the future.
- Private health insurance companies save part of your monthly contributions to compensate for future increases in medical costs.

So, if you are a high earner and believe you'll continue to earn high in the future, you should consider moving to private health insurance. Besides that, everyone should save a cushion to cover their medical expenses in old age.

Private health insurance is a complicated product. So, we recommend consulting a fee-based advisor or an insurance broker for personalized advice.

Resources

Useful links

- **Public health insurance:** Register with TK online here.
- **Private health insurance**: Book an appointment with the insurance broker we recommend here.
- **Expat health insurance:** We found the expat health insurance from Feather* and Dr-Walter* among the best.
- **Health Insurance Finder:** Tool that assists you in finding the right health insurance based on your personal situation. The tool is free and we don't ask for your email to use it.
- **Private health insurance minimum coverage checklist:** You should take this checklist with you when consulting an insurance broker. Ensure your policy covers the points mentioned in this checklist.
- **Our guides:** We update our guides more often than this book. Hence, we recommend checking out our guides time to time for the most up to date information.

Other books

- Expats guide to buy a house in Germany

Disclaimer

The information provided in this book/document is based on our own experience and in-depth research. Its content might be inaccurate. It should not be considered financial, tax, legal, or any kind of advice.

We are not certified brokers or consultants. Always do your own research and contact certified professionals before making any decision.

We finance our extensive work via affiliate links. Thus, some or all of the links in the document might be affiliate links. We get money if you click on such a link or conclude a contract with the provider without costing you a cent extra.

All links marked with the “*” are affiliate links.

Version History

Version	Last modified on	Changes
1.0	10 Sep. 2024	Finished the first version of the book
1.1	11 Sep. 2024	Added book cover, other useful resoruces